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OFFICIAL REPORT

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Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Thursday, 19th March, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 1:18 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR,
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to the item numbered 5, *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I have the *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 18th March 2026, for correction.

Page 1...35— Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much.

With your permission, let me congratulate the Clerks-at-the-Table; they have done so well. The name of the Committee on the page numbered 35, which is “Committee on Public Administration and State Interest”, the “Interest” should be plural.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, take note.

Page 36...39— Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Afriyie: On the page numbered 38, the item numbered 2(ii), under the title written as “Attendance”, the name of the Member for Upper Manya Krobo which is Mr Bismark Tetteh Nyarko, has been wrongly spelt.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, check the spelling of the “Nyarko”. Thank you for that observation.

Page 39...42.

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 18th March, 2026, as corrected is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

We have the *Official Report* of Thursday, 12th March, 2026, for correction. Hon Members, any correction? Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, with respect, I invite you to the column numbered 19, the paragraph numbered 2, the name of the Minister of State for Climate Change and Sustainability, Mr Issifu Baba Seidu as written is wrongly captured. The name “Seidu” has been captured wrongly. If the Clerks-at-the-Table could take note.

Once again, on the column numbered 106, on the last paragraph, the reference made to Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor, by way of his designation, is wrong. He is the Majority

Chief Whip but it is captured as “Second Deputy Majority Whip”. Mr Speaker, the demotion is not acceptable.

On the column numbered 114, on the very last paragraph, the line numbered 5, “District Assembly Common Fund”, the “Assembly” should be deleted and the plural, “Assemblies” inserted.

The very last one, is on the column numbered 158, the paragraph 3, Mr Richmond Edem Kofi Kpotosu is referred here as a Member of Parliament for the New Patriotic Party (NPP). The record should be corrected. We would not dash our Members to the other Side.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, take note of the corrections.

Hon Members, any further corrections?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 109, the column numbered 1, the paragraph numbered 4, the Second Deputy Speaker referred the Statement, in pursuance of my prayer, to the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs. But the referral reference is missing. So, if the Table Office can indicate that.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further corrections?

Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Thursday, 12th April, 2026, as corrected

is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, with your indulgence, I acknowledge the presence of students from MUMISCO, led by Mr Sebastian Kekee Ampem, the headmaster. They are from the Asuogyaman Constituency and are 77 in number.

[Pupils of MUMISCO were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We also have Ayeldu St. Augustine Catholic Basic School, led by Mr Enock Adjei, a teacher. They are from the Abura Asebu Kwamankese and are 50 in Number.

[Pupils of Ayeldu St. Augustine Catholic Basic School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We also have the University of Business and Integrated Development Studies, led by Professor Thaddeus Aasoglenang, a lecturer. They are from Wa Central and are 13 in number.

[Students of University of Business and Integrated Development Studies were acknowledged.]

Hon Members, we also have Ahtoo Montessori School, led by Dr Samuel Perbi Appiah.

1:28 p.m.

Dr Samuel Perbi Appiah is the proprietor and they are from Ayawaso Central; they are 49 in number.

Hon Members, on your behalf I welcome them to the Parliament of Ghana and urge them to have a fruitful visit. Kindly resume your seats.

[Students of Ahtoo Montessori Schools were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the item numbered 6, Business Statement for the Eighth Week.

Hon Majority Leader, you have the floor.

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE

Chairperson of the Business Committee/Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, your Committee met yesterday because tomorrow is a public holiday, so we did not hold the usual Thursday meetings. Yesterday, Wednesday 18th March, 2026 the Committee met and arranged Business of the House for the Eighth Week ending Friday, 27th March, 2026.

Mr Speaker, the Committee accordingly submits its report as follows:

Arrangement of Business

Formal Communication by the Speaker

Mr Speaker, you may read any available communication to the House.

Statements

Mr Speaker, pursuant to Order 91(2), Ministers of State may be permitted to

make Statements on Government policy. You may also admit Statements by Hon Members in accordance with Order 93.

Bills, Papers and Reports

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 159, Bills may be presented to the House for First Reading. However, those of urgent nature may be taken through the various stages in a day, in accordance with Order 160.

Pursuant to Order 97, Papers may be laid during the week and reports from Committees may also be presented to the House for consideration.

Motions and Resolutions

Mr Speaker, Motions may be debated and their consequential Resolutions, if any, taken during the week.

Referrals at Committee

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee has observed that there is a total of Two Hundred and Ninety-One (291) referrals at Committees and is once again urging the Committees to expedite work on the referral for the consideration of the House in accordance with Order 267(4).

Sitting Time and Extended Sittings

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee recommends that, in the ensuing week, sitting of the House should commence at 10:00 a.m. each day. This is to afford the House ample time to consider the outstanding business of the House before adjourning *sine die*.

Mr Speaker, the Committee further recommends that Questions and Statements would not be scheduled in the ensuing week. This is to afford the House ample time to dispense with the consideration of outstanding Bills. The Committee entreats all Leadership of Committees to avail themselves in the House during the considerations of the Bills referred to their respective Committees.

Adjournment of the House

Mr Speaker, the House is expected to adjourn *sine die* on Friday, 27th March, 2026. In view of this, the Business Committee entreats all Hon Members to devote themselves to the scheduled business for the week to enable the House adjourn on the proposed date.

The Business Committee takes this opportunity to commend you, Mr Speaker, your Deputies, and all Hon Members for the dedication to the Business of the House during this First Meeting. The Business Committee urges all Hon Members to continue with this commitment until the House adjourns *sine die*.

The Business Committee also wishes all Hon Members a happy *Eid-ul-Fitr*. The Committee remains hopeful that we all will return in the best of health for the business of the Second Meeting.

Conclusion

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 216(2) and subject to Order 67, the Committee submits to the House the order in which the Business of the House shall be taken during the week.

Monday, 23rd March, 2026

National Holiday

Tuesday, 24th March, 2026

Roll Call

National Pledge

Statements

Presentation of Papers

- (a) Special Audit Report of the Auditor-General on Government outstanding claims and Commitments as at 31st December, 2024.
- (b) Report of the Committee on Public Administration and State Interests on the Ghana Investment Promotion Authority Bill, 2025.
- (c) Report of the Committee on Roads and Transportation on the Maritime and Related Offences Bill, 2026.

Presentation and First Reading of Bills.

Ghana Investment Promotion Authority Bill, 2025.

Motions

Second Reading of Bills

- Ghana Investment Promotion Authority Bill, 2025.

- Maritime and Related Offences Bill, 2026.

Consideration Stage

- Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025 - *(Continuation)*
- Intestate Succession Bill, 2025 - *(Continuation)*
- Governance Advisory Council Bill, 2025.
- Ghana Deposit Protection (Amendment) Bill, 2025.
- Value for Money Office Bill, 2026 - *(Continuation)*
- Community Service Bill, 2026 - *(Continuation)*

Committee Sittings

Wednesday, 25th March, 2026

Roll Call

Statements

Motions

Consideration Stage

- Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025 - *(Continuation)*
- Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025 - *(Continuation)*

- Intestate Succession Bill, 2025 - *(Continuation)*

- Governance Advisory Council Bill, 2025.

- Ghana Deposit Protection (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

- Value for Money Office Bill, 2026 - *(Continuation)*

- University of Engineering and Agricultural Sciences Bill, 2025.

- Community Service Bill, 2026 - *(Continuation)*

Committee Sittings.

Thursday, 26th March, 2026

Roll Call

Statements

Motions

Third Reading of Bills

- Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025.

- Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025.

- Intestate Succession Bill, 2025.

- Governance Advisory Council Bill, 2025.

- Ghana Deposit Protection (Amendment) Bill, 2025.
- Value for Money Office Bill, 2026.
- University of Engineering and Agricultural Sciences Bill, 2025.
- Community Service Bill, 2026.

Consideration Stage

- Ghana Investment Promotion Authority Bill, 2025.
- Maritime and Related Offences Bill, 2026.

Committee Sittings

Friday, 27th March, 2026

Roll Call

Presentation of Papers

Motions

Third Reading of Bills

- Ghana Investment Promotion Authority Bill, 2025.
- Maritime and Related Offences Bill, 2026.

Committee Sittings

The House expected to adjourn *sine die*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Business Statement ably presented. It is now for your comments. Any comments?

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, let me first thank the Leader of the House for presenting the Business of the House for the ensuing week.

Mr Speaker, I do not want this to be business as usual. The items that as captured in the Business Committee's Report must find space on the Floor and we must ensure that. Since we started, we have had this pending Motion, on the Ghana Gold Board (GOLDBOD). In the first week, the understanding was that we were going to take this Motion. Each time, the applicants will prepare, come and we are unable to take them. There is a second one on the gold that the Bank of Ghana sold, 18 tonnes. Our Colleagues also filed that Motion. The Motion was admitted and that has not found space in the *Order Paper*.

Mr Speaker, I would want the Majority Leader to ensure that at least we take the motion on GOLDBOD on Tuesday. The understanding was that we were going to take it today but we know the circumstance of the day because of the *Eid-ul-Fitr* tomorrow and Members are busy and all of that. Though our Side is prepared for it, we are also aware that he would want to get Ministers of State to be part of the debate. We know Mr President is not in Accra. We would agree with that. It is only fair that all Sides are ahead in this important matter.

Mr Speaker, I would plead with that concession coming from the Minority, we would not pursue the Motion numbered 46 at page 30 of today's *Order Paper* in good faith that on Tuesday, the government side will be ready to deal with this GOLDBOD matter. This is because it is becoming one too many and this House must be seen to be interrogating the issues. That is issue number one.

Mr Speaker, issue number two. Yesterday, we had a high privilege and distinct honour as Leaders to meet with the Managing Director and Chief Knowledge Officer of the World Bank, Mr Pascal Donohoe. Some of the issues that came up were very serious. The World Bank has warned that the entry of 1.2 billion young people into developing country labour markets over the next decade would deepen a global job deficit due to a widening gap between education systems and evolving job markets. Speaking at the University of Ghana, Mr Pascal Donohoe highlighted that the weak learning outcomes, limited education levels, and rapid changes driven by technology are leaving many youths unprepared, especially in Africa where job creation lags behind workforce growth. The Bank, therefore, is prioritising education reform, skill development, and entrepreneurship.

Mr Speaker, we want concrete policies by the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry, to tap into the support that World Bank wants to give. In yesterday's discussion, the issues were very clear. I would want the Majority Leader to programme the two

Ministers to tell us what policy decisions there are within government circles to promote entrepreneurship because the World Bank is going to advance some support to us. Again, to the Minister for Education; the emphasis yesterday was on vocational training and apprenticeship. Enough of the white-collar certificates that we are emphasising on. He must come up with a policy on apprenticeship so that our young people can take advantage of.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Education must be programmed to come and deal with this matter to assure the youth that if they enter into apprenticeship, it does not mean that they do not belong to society.

1:38 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the third issue has to do with *galamsey*. Mr Speaker, our President is on a regional tour. He himself has stated that there is widespread *galamsey* and he expects that political leaders, traditional and community groups must support—[*Interruption*—the *galamsey* issue.

Mr Speaker, Mr President has acknowledged the fact that *galamsey* is getting out of hand and is now calling on political leaders, traditional leaders and community leaders to assist in this fight. Mr Speaker, according to Mr President, the stakeholders he has mentioned are making it difficult to eliminate this *galamsey* menace, especially when it comes to enforcement. He has linked the issue partly to low cocoa prices pushing farmers into mining and noted that

although challenges such as limited resources hinder efforts; Government remains committed to tackling the problem. Mr Speaker, I am not interested in the President's commitment. I am interested in concrete policies; how people are going to be punished, what we are going to put in place at the ports to discourage the importation of *Changfang* equipment; those machines. The Minister for Lands and Natural Resources must lead in this all-important drive.

Mr Buah — *rose* —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I would want to see the Minister being programmed by the Majority Leader to come into this Chamber to apprise this House regarding steps that he is taking at his Ministry.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources has been on his feet for some time. So, let me just give him the floor. Yes, Minister, why are you up?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let me finish. He can use contempt. He can use Privileges Committee. If you think I have misquoted the President, go to the Privileges Committee. That is the right approach. Take me to the Privileges Committee if you think I have misquoted the President.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Emmanuel Armah Kofi Buah?

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-

Kofi Buah) (MP): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I think it is important to know that finally, we have a President who is always ready to level with Ghanaians with integrity and honesty. A question was asked about the fight and whether he is aware that in his own party, some people can be involved. He said he does not kid himself that some individuals in his own party are involved. But the President did not say that there is a widespread increase in *galamsey*.

In fact, the President is very proud of what we have done, the mess we have been cleaning up. For one year, Mr Speaker, we have basically liberated our forest. That was a no-go area. We are cleaning up water that was damaged by our Friends here. So we are making a lot of progress in the fight against *galamsey*. But we do not kid ourselves that the problem is 100 per cent solved. That is exactly what the President alluded to. I knew that, so do not misquote the President.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, you will have your turn to contribute to the Business Statement.

Mr Buah: We are honest and levelling with the people of Ghana. We are proud of the fight we are putting up with all the initiatives, Blue Water, National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, you will have your turn. Hon Minority Leader, we agreed to create a space for you when we come to

Statements. That was the agreement. So, I am quite surprised that the time for Business Statement, contrary to the agreement that we have reached — We said you will be allotted space during the time of Statements.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, maybe you have misconstrued it. That one is in respect of the helicopter crash. These are national issues that, as a Minority, I have a duty to bring it up for the Leader of Government Business. I can be brief on the issues —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, if you look at Standing Order 93, during the time for Statements, you can seek leave of the Speaker to draw the attention to a matter of urgent public importance or personal nature, but not during the time of Business Statement.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I take a cue. But Mr Speaker, I would want to encourage the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources that there is every unfettered opportunity for him in this House to come and share his success story. He should use ministerial Statements to come and address us. The President acknowledges that his own people are doing *galamsey* and the Minister himself just quoted Mr President. So I did not even bring that up.

Mr Dafeamekpor — *rose* —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: You brought it up. So let us not go there. But I have taken a cue from Mr Speaker and I would therefore— *[Interruption]* — Yes, that was what he said.

So, Mr Speaker, I would hold the other matters for the Statement.

But let me just end on this point. That in the Upper West Region, there is severe shortage of workforce. There is no single doctor, according to reports. It is reported that there is no single doctor in the Upper West Region. No single doctor in the Upper West Region, Mr Speaker. *[Interruption]*

Yes. So I am saying that the Minister should come and confirm. If the contrary is the issue, the Minister should come. That is why we want that to be addressed by the Minister.

Mr Speaker, let me hold the other matters under Order 93 of the Standing Orders, so that we can close the Business Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip, I saw you on your feet.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, indeed, yes. A statement has been ascribed to the President, to the effect that he said that his own people are doing *galamsey*. Mr Speaker, nothing of that sort has been reported anywhere. The President, indeed, never said so. So the Minority Leader cannot make such a suggestion on the Floor and we allow it to stand. Mr Speaker, it ought to be deleted.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I have not, on this Floor of the House, been a primary source of what the President has said about his own

party. Let us call for the *Hansard*. The audiovisuals should bring back—I have never talked about Mr President talking about *galamsey*. His own Minister said the President acknowledged that his party members are engaged in *galamsey*. Let us get the audiovisual. I am not a primary source of that. Your own Minister said Mr President has acknowledged that some party members are involved in *galamsey*. In any event, Organised Labour on May Day last year stated emphatically that *galamsey* had gotten out of hand since the NDC assumed office. Go and check on the Internet. Organised Labour said that boldly in its official statement on May Day.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think, given the issues that have been raised about what the President said, it would be appropriate to quote the President verbatim. This is what the President said:

“Even when one party changes, those who are running some operation, who went to one party, will go to the next party and say, now that you have come, come and take over this operation and let us share. We too will be getting small. This is what we are doing. And so, I do not kid myself that we do not have our own people involved.”

1:48 p.m.

This is in response to a question asked about whether National Democratic Congress (NDC) members were involved in *galamsey* activities. The President spoke about the tendency

of people, when there is a change in government, to now approach those who are in Government and try to recruit them to participate in *galamsey* by handing over their equipment to them. The President then said that despite that, he is very proud of his record so far in the fight against *galamsey*, and went ahead to outline all the measures that have been implemented to deal with the problem of *galamsey*. All the equipment that are held up at the port which would have been out there in the forest causing deforestation and polluting our water bodies stand as evidence of the work that he has done. Clearing certain forests of illegal miners stand as testimony of the work that he has done.

Mr Speaker, I have said it repeatedly that the problem of *galamsey* was aggravated by the involvement of heavy earth-moving machinery. Today we can confidently say that those earth-moving machinery are not in the field carrying out *galamsey* activities. The artisanal mining that has been going on since ancient Ghana empire would be difficult for us to stop completely. Artisanal mining where the young people with their pickaxes and shovels are digging and trying to process to get their small-scale mining gold, that has been with us for ages. What created the problem was when foreigners moved in and started pre-financing our indigenes with earth-moving equipment.

So, what we needed to deal with was to take out those earth-moving equipment. But we cannot totally deprive those young people of the use of their labour in the way that they have been

doing historically. As far back as when I was a law student, I recall being a research assistant to my lecturer who was proposing the new small-scale mining laws, and I went to all the mining sites in this country. At that time, more than 25 years ago, I saw artisanal mining activities, this *galamsey* that we are talking about today, but it was small-scale and they were just using pickaxes, shovels, digging and processing it. Some of the big mines today moved to those locations because of the activities of these artisanal miners. That is how they discovered that there was gold there. So, this has been with us for a very long time.

What was not with us was the huge excavators and huge bull-dozer. I know that a lot of it was financed by bigwigs in certain parties and certain governments. That is not happening any longer. That is why the President is proud of his record to say, “look, I have done as much as I can”. It is in this same House that we know that people are being prosecuted in court today; so, the evidence is manifest. Mr Speaker, we are proud of our record in dealing with the issue of *galamsey*. And the President said, “I am not kidding myself. It is possible that my own party people are involved, but I am doing a lot of work”.

It is true that the Hon Minority Leader has a Motion pending and we have had some discussions and are hoping that early next week we can take the Motion. I can assure him that this Central Bank governor is an excellent gentleman. Within one year we can see

the stability that he has brought to the currency of this country. Within one year we can see how diligently he has restored the integrity of the financial sector of this country. We can see how the banking sector has been revived. Interest rates have come down and there is liquidity in the system. I know many of them are being chased by their banks so that they can come and take loans, because there is so much liquidity in the system and the interest rates are low. So, this Central Bank governor has done so well and this Side of the House is ready to debate his track record. We are very proud of it.

As for GOLDBOD, it is our major achievement. The establishment of the GOLDBOD and the method by which we have convinced small-scale miners to sell the gold to Government that we are able to build reserves that we have used to stabilise the currency; we are very proud of that track record. We are not saying that there will be no cost. There is always cost to progress. Progress costs some money, success costs some money, and stability costs some money. So, there will be cost and we are ready to debate that cost.

Now, youth unemployment. As for youth unemployment, it is a reality. The numbers that are applying for the recruitment into the security agencies is definitely a wake-up call. For what the World Bank President has said, I can assure the House that when we invite the Minister for Education, Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment and Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry, using the proper channels, they

will come and brief us as to what we are doing differently to try and create jobs for our youth. I know that there are mechanisms by which we bring Ministers to this House.

And again, every Friday I seem to have to remind the Hon Minority Leader that we do not bring Ministers to this House by getting up on Friday and saying that Ministers have to be brought to this House. He knows that Ministers are brought to this House when they are being asked Questions. We ask the Minister a Question, “What are you doing to create employment for the youth of this country?”, the Minister will come and answer. We ask the Minister for Education, “What are you doing to ensure that they acquire the relevant skills?” The Minister for Education will come and then answer. But he does not ask Questions, then on Friday he will get up and say everything about unemployment. How is he helping the youth by just talking about unemployment? So, he should ask the Questions and the Ministers will come and answer.

Mr Speaker, on that note, let me thank the Minority Leader for raising these issues. We work as a team. The Motion will be taken next week. If he asks the relevant Questions, we will bring the Ministers. As for the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, he is busy in the field solving the problem. It is better for us to see manifestation of the solution on the ground than he just coming to make Statements on the Floor.

So, I can assure the House that work is being done. We are making a lot of progress. *galamsey* is being fought effectively. In addition to that, he is working very hard as the Acting Minister for Environment, Science, and Technology to reclaim the areas that several years of digging has created across the country. So, there is a serious programme of reclamation going on. *[Interruption]* So they should ask him a Question and he will come and answer the Question. Mr Speaker, I thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Business Statement as presented is hereby adopted. We then move to the next item.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I pray for variation of the order of Business, so that we take the Motion numbered 36 so that the Minister for Education—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, the application is to take the Motion numbered 36.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am still worried about the inability of the Majority Chief Whip to consult. This is a business of consultation. It is not a one-Sided Parliament. So, if he wants to vary something, he should engage. But we know who is involved, so we should engage and then let us come back to the Speaker.

BILL — THIRD READING**University of Engineering and
Agricultural Sciences Bill, 2025**

**Minister for Education (Mr Haruna
Idrisu):** Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That the University of Engineering
and Agricultural Sciences Bill, 2025
be now read the Third time.

1:58 p.m.

**Chairman of the Committee (Mr
Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe):** Mr
Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

The University of Engineering and
Agricultural Sciences Bill, 2025 — *read
the Third time and passed.*

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker,
before we come to the item numbered 7,
may I pray that we take the item
numbered 8 to lay the Report of the
Committee on Lands and Natural
Resources. Mr Speaker, the Chairperson
of the Committee just stepped out, so I
pray that the Member of the Committee,
Hon Richard Acheampong, does so on
behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon
Members at the Commencement of
Public Business, Presentation of Papers,
the item numbered 8.

PAPER

*By the Second Deputy Majority Whip
(Mr Richard Acheampong) on behalf of
the Chairperson of the Committee —*

Report of the Committee on Lands
and Natural Resources on the Mining
Lease Agreement Between the
Government of the Republic of
Ghana (represented by the Ministry
of Lands and Natural Resources) and
Barari DV Ghana Limited for the
mining of Lithium and other minerals
at Mankessim (42.63 km²) in the
Mfantseman Municipality of the
Central Region.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon
Members, the Paper has been duly
presented, and it is for distribution to
Hon Members.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may
we take the item numbered 6—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item
numbered 5, we have taken the Business
Statement—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the
item numbered 7. May I pray you in
pursuance of Order 93(1) to make a
Statement in respect of a matter of urgent
public interest. Mr Speaker, three days
ago, a private helicopter crashed —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please,
go ahead.

STATEMENTS

Microlight Aircraft Crash at Tema Community 1

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. It was a small plane, I should say, that crashed at Tema Community 1 Site 18 near the Oninku Primary School. Mr Speaker, two persons on board, the pilot and another, have been declared dead. This matter has traumatised the nation, especially Tema, and it is important that as Parliament, we commiserate with the family of the two persons on board and also the fact that it escaped crashing on the school field of the Tema Oninku Primary School. As a House, we commiserate with the families of the deceased. We would want to call the attention of the Ghana Air Force, as well as the private entity that owns this aircraft; we are informed that they own other aircrafts. They should take maintenance matters seriously.

Mr Speaker, on this note, we wish the bereaved family our deepest condolences. I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Charles Forson (NPP — Tema Central): Mr Speaker, I associate myself with the message as delivered by the Majority Chief Whip concerning the light plane which crashed near Oninku Basic School. It is adjoining to my constituency, which is Tema East, and I sincerely do appreciate the comment as made by the Majority Chief Whip. Thank you.

Mr Isaac Ashai Odamtten (NDC — Tema East): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. Indeed, I would want to extend condolences to the bereaved families and also to stand with the people of Tema East for the tragic and unfortunate incident which occurred when the light sports plane forcefully landed, crashed, and caught fire in my constituency in Tema Community 1. We can only commiserate with the affected families and also take a cue from such happenings. May I also say that we were fortunate that, even though it was a day the children were supposed to be in school, when it happened, it did not affect other lives apart from those two passengers.

Indeed, the situation exposes us as a people to how we show preparedness in the face of such emergency situations. The way this incident occurred would call attention to us as a nation to resource the agencies with the responsibility to attend to such situations when they occur. Mr Speaker, I want to commend the leadership of Tema Metropolitan Assembly, headed by Hon Ebi Bright, for the prompt response on that day to ensure that the security services who were on the grounds to perform their activities were given the space to do that. I would also want to put on record that the response rate of the National Ghana Fire Service (GNFS) for the Tema region Fire Service was very commendable. In addition to that, all key state actors did a good job, and the following day, the way in which they protected the evidence for further investigations was also commendable.

I would want to thank my Leadership for giving me this space to share these few thoughts. Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, I rise on behalf of my Colleagues on this Side of the House with grief and deep concern following the tragic microlight aircraft crash that occurred on Monday, 16th March, 2026, at approximately 2:49 p.m. within the Tema Community 1 Site 18 on the compound of the Tema Metropolitan Assembly Nursery School near Oninku Park.

Mr Speaker, as reported, a privately owned Sky Arrow microlight aircraft with registration number NG-ADV lost control while attempting to land after flying from Ho to Accra. The aircraft crashed and burst into flames within a populated area, tragically claiming the lives of two Ghanaian citizens: Captain Frank Amwenin Donkor, aged 36, a highly experienced pilot and a certified flight instructor, and his brother, Elijah Ofori Donkor, aged 25, a promising university graduate. Mr Speaker, the Minority extends its deepest condolences to the bereaved family, particularly the parents and relatives of the two brothers, their friends, colleagues in the aviation sector, and all who have been affected by this tragedy. These were the cherished sons of Elder Frank Kwabena Donkor, founder of the Hebron Prayer Camp. May the Almighty grant comfort and strength to the family and all who mourn.

Mr Speaker, by the grace of God, there were no extended casualties.

2:08 p.m.

The school children, teachers, and members of the public on the ground were not harmed. But let me, on behalf of my Colleagues, acknowledge the swift and heroic response of teachers, members of the public, and first responders, including the Ghana National Fire Service, the Police, and National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO) that ensured that the fire was contained and no further loss was sustained.

Mr Speaker, beyond mourning, this incident raises serious questions that demand urgent answers. As you are well aware, our Colleagues who lost their lives in the helicopter crash on the 6th of August, 2025, to date, we in this House do not have the full reports that was commissioned by His Excellency the President. We therefore urgently demand the following from the authorities:

1. How was a privately-owned microlight aircraft allowed to operate over a densely populated corridor with such a devastating consequence?
2. Were all safety protocols, maintenance procedure, and pilot certification strictly observed?
3. What regulatory oversight existed and why did it fail to prevent this disaster?
4. Could this tragedy have been prevented with stronger monitoring and enforcement?

Mr Speaker, the fact that a private aircraft could traverse civilian airspace and crash within a populated area underscores systemic failures in risk management, oversight, and enforcement. Our country, Ghana, cannot continue to normalise preventable disasters. Leadership demands accountability, and the Government, we respectfully submit, must act decisively.

Mr Speaker, in the light of this tragedy, the Minority respectfully calls on the relevant authorities to conduct a full, transparent, and independent, as well as time-bound investigation with findings made public, detailing the cause of the crash, any lapses in certification, maintenance, and operational procedures, and corrective measures to prevent reoccurrence; review and strengthen aviation safety protocols for all microlight and private aircrafts, particularly in or near densely populated areas; ensure adequate resourcing of investigative and regulatory bodies to guarantee rigorous monitoring and enforcement; and finally, establish a support system for bereaved families, providing timely assistance and care to mitigate the impact of such tragedies.

Mr Speaker, our Side of this House will continue to follow this matter closely and support every measure aimed at protecting lives, strengthening aviation safety, and ensuring that preventable tragedies do not occur again.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, the Minority hereby reiterates, as we even mourn the loss of Captain Frank Donkor and Elijah Donkor, that this tragedy

should serve as a call to action. It must compel Government to enforce safety regulations, strengthen oversight, and protect the lives of all Ghanaians. We owe it a duty to the departed, their family, and the nation to ensure that preventable tragedies like this never happen again. The nation must not be seen only to be mourning when the individuals involved are public officers. Everybody in our country matters to the extent that they are citizens. They have rights, far rights. May their souls rest in perfect peace and rest in the everlasting hands of our Maker.

Mr Speaker, I thank you so much for this treasured space.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Side?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I pray that we take a minute's silence, then we have two more Statements.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So that brings us to the end of that Statement?

Mr Dafeamekpor: That is so.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, may we stand up and observe a minute's silence.

[A minute's silence was observed.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have a commemorative Statement which stands in the name of the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, Hon Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah.

Hon Minister, you have the floor.

Commemoration of the 2026 International Day of Forests

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this Statement ahead of the global observance of the 2026 International Day of Forests, which is celebrated annually on the 21st of March. Proclaimed by the United Nations General Assembly in 2012, this day serves to raise global awareness about the immeasurable role forests play in sustaining life on earth and supporting the livelihood of millions across the globe.

Mr Speaker, this year's theme, "Forests and Economies", is an imperative clarion call that compels us to reimagine our relationship with nature. It invites us to recognise forests not merely as resources to be extracted and exhausted, but as living assets, complex ecosystems that, when managed sustainably, can generate enduring wealth, create dignified livelihoods, and anchor our national development in ecological wisdom.

Mr Speaker, forests are no longer just ecological treasures. They are powerful engines of national prosperity. Globally, forests cover approximately one-third of the earth's land surface and support the livelihoods of more than 1.6 billion people. The global forest sector contributes hundreds of billions of dollars annually to the world economy and provides employment for millions

across forestry, agriculture, manufacturing, tourism, and ecosystem services.

In Ghana, the forest sector contributes significantly to our national development. Timber exports alone earn approximately €100 million annually, while local consumption of wildlife and forest products is valued at over US\$250 million annually. Beyond exports, forests regulate rainfall patterns, protect watersheds, and maintain soil fertility. Our protected forest areas and national parks attract both domestic and international tourists, generating income for local communities and the national economy. Additionally, our forests provide medicinal and aromatic plants that support both traditional and modern healthcare systems. About 75 per cent of our rural communities rely on fuel wood as their major energy source for cooking and other domestic needs.

Mr Speaker, four months ago, I had the distinct privilege of leading Ghana's delegation to the 30th Conference of the Parties, COP30, to the UN Framework Conference on Climate Change, held at the heart of the Amazon, in Belém, Brazil. A central pillar of this discussion at COP30 is the role of forests in the global carbon market. We are witnessing the emergence of a new economic reality where a standing thriving tree is not just an ecological asset, but a financial one.

2:18 p.m.

Through verified carbon credits, countries like Ghana that demonstrate a commitment to protecting and restoring our forests can access significant

financial flows from the international community.

Mr Speaker, despite these immense benefits, Ghana's forests continue to face serious threats; deforestation, illegal logging, unsustainable agricultural expansion, bushfires and illegal mining (*galamsey*) activities have significantly degraded many of our forest landscapes. These practices not only destroy our biodiversity but also threaten our water bodies, soil fertility and the long-term sustainability of our natural resources. If we fail to protect our forests today, the economic, environment and social consequences will be severe for future generations. The loss of forest leads to declining agricultural productivity, increased vulnerability to climate change, loss of biodiversity and the destruction of livelihoods for millions of Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, it is therefore very paramount that we take deliberate and collective action to protect, restore and sustainably manage our forest resources. Through the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources and its implementing agencies—particularly the Forestry Commission—the Government continues to implement policies and programmes aimed at safeguarding our forests while promoting sustainable economic growth.

One of the flagship initiatives is the Tree for Life Reforestation Initiative, launched by His Excellency President John Dramani Mahama in 2025 at Nkawie in the Ashanti Region to restore degraded mined-out areas and other ecologically sensitive landscapes. I am

pleased to report that against a target of 30 million seedlings in 2025, we successfully distributed and planted over 30 million trees across the country.

More importantly, Mr Speaker, this was a people-powered achievement that created over 41,000 green jobs. We salute our 2,600 Youth Forest Champions, over 20,000 farmers under the Modified Taungya System and thousands more in nurseries and the private sector who made this happen. They are the vanguard of Ghana's green revolution.

Mr Speaker, this morning on behalf of H.E. the President, I launched the 2026 edition of the Tree for Life Reforestation Initiative at the Achimota Forest Reserve — the “Green Heart” of our capital city. Our target for 2026 is another 30 million seedlings to be planted across the country. I call on all Members of this August House to embrace this tree planting exercise when we commence this tree planting in June during the rainy season. But we must do more than plant. We must nurture. A seedling is a promise; a mature tree is a legacy.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry is also strengthening forest governance and enforcement measures to combat illegal logging and illegal mining in forest reserves. We are working closely with security agencies, forest guards, traditional authorities, civil society organisations and local communities to protect our forest resources from further degradation.

Additionally, Ghana continues to collaborate with international partners under various climate and forest conservation programmes. I am proud to note that in August 2025, Ghana became the first African country — and the second globally, after Indonesia — to issue a Forest Law Enforcement, Governance and Trade (FLEGT) licence for the export of legally produced timber to the European market. This achievement places Ghana on the world stage as a leader in environmental sustainability and climate action.

As we commemorate this year's International Day of the Forests, I wish to call on all stakeholders and all Ghanaians to join hands in protecting and restoring Ghana's forests.

On behalf of the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources, I encourage all Ghanaians to actively participate in the 2026 Tree for Life Reforestation Initiative. Let us remember that healthy forests mean healthy economies, healthy ecosystems and healthy communities.

As Franklin D. Roosevelt wisely stated: "A nation that destroys its soils destroys itself." Forests are the lungs of our land, purifying the air and giving fresh strength to our people. So, we must collectively work to protect our forests.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for your attention and may God bless our homeland Ghana. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that is the Statement made by the Minister for Lands and Natural

Resources. Giving the exigencies of time, how many contributors do we take?

Leadership?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we will take two each from each Side and leadership making three.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah, you have the floor.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah (NPP — Okaikwei Central): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make some few comments. Mr Speaker, as the Minister was making his Statement, I decided to make a few checks and that in 2024, I thought he was going to report on this in his Statement, that the World Bank gave us US\$20 million; US\$30 million grant from the United Arab Emirates (UAE), and US\$54.5 million for the Northern Afforestation Programme. In total, about US\$100 million for the forestry sector in 2024. I thought I was going to hear the Minister give us an update on where we are on some of these initiatives.

The Minister also mentioned that he has planted and led a Tree for Life Reforestation Initiative with about 30 million trees. And he could not give us an update on where these trees are, their distribution, the districts who benefited among others. We needed to know, Mr Speaker. It is very important. Because Mr Speaker, back to the Statement, we should not be proud as a country that we have lost over 80 per cent of our forest cover. And now we have to rely on

donors to give us money for reforestation? It is not a good Statement to have come from us as a people that we sat down and saw today's serious degradation through illegal mining that has led to statements being issued by Presidents and Ministers of State on how we have not been able to manage our own affairs in areas of forestry maintenance and what have you.

Look at our river bodies. Everybody wants to be a millionaire overnight. Mining in forest reserves are the detriment of generations to come. Mr Speaker, I think the Minister and the Government must take this matter seriously. We have played a lot of politics with our forest and our river bodies and it is about time that we acted seriously. The President gave this country hope that he was going to fight illegal mining in our forest reserves and other places. But here is the situation that the President is telling us that *galamsey* is a very difficult issue to fight. We want to see more action in the preservation of our forest and river bodies. I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Frank Afriyie?

Mr Frank Afriyie (NDC — Afadjato South): Mr Speaker, thank you so much. Let me also use this auspicious occasion to thank the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources. Indeed, the relevance of our need to maintain and preserve our forest cover lies in the symbiotic relationship between humans and forest. And to that extent, I am happy to note that even

though His Excellency President John Dramani Mahama has inherited a very sorrowful state as far as forest cover and *galamsey* activities are concerned, he has demonstrated political will and willingness to fight this particular menace. As we speak, more than nine of the forest cover which previously served as no-go areas have been reclaimed and we are doing well. We are not there yet, but I think that significantly we have made some progress. Indeed, our water bodies are showing incremental signs of recovery.

Mr Speaker, the truth is that any time we elect to fight nature, nature will bounce back and fight us several times. We cannot degrade our environment. We cannot decimate our environment. We cannot pollute our water bodies and expect that they will keep serving us.

2:28 p.m.

Indeed, we have a collective responsibility, whether in Government or in opposition, to maintain the environment in which we live. The soundness, the ecological integrity of our forest cover, is at the heart of how we are able to get the food, the medicine and everything that we derive from our forest cover. Indeed, I am happy to hear from the Minister that the Tree for Life programme for this year is aimed at planting some 30 million seedlings.

We in Afadjato South, where we have the highest mountain, have voluntarily decided that we will not destroy our environment. We are keeping our forest cover. What we need

is a serious Government bailout. The attention being given to *galamsey* areas in an attempt to reclaim this land, part of which will also be directed to, and this is a special appeal to the Minister, those of us who are not giving the Government a headache. In Afadjato South, the Minister should come and see our forest cover. Our youth also need some of the attention that is being given to the *galamsey* areas.

Mr Speaker, for me, it is mind-boggling, and it is inexcusable that *galamsey* is going on in certain communities, and the Chiefs are there. Therefore, we must appeal to the National House of Chiefs to ensure that these Chiefs are assigned special Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) and that anything that occurs within their jurisdiction is their responsibility. I commend the Otumfuo very well; at least we have seen him remove some of these Chiefs from their thrones. We must scale this up to the national level.

Indeed, Police Commanders and Service Chiefs in the various districts and assemblies are responsible for ensuring that those destroying our environment are checked. They have no duty to be a Police Commander if they cannot perform these basic responsibilities.

Mr Speaker, I want to use the occasion once again to thank the Minister and to commend him, and to assure him that we, in this august House, will join him to win the battle eventually. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Akwasi Konadu.

Mr Akwasi Konadu (NPP — Manhyia North): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for giving me this space to add my voice to the Statement delivered by the Hon Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, who also doubles as the Acting Minister for Environment.

Mr Speaker, it is important that we celebrate this day; however, what do we see? Our forest is under siege. It is not by nature, or by accident. It is driven by human greed, a lack of political will to enforce, policy rebranding, and inertia. It is important to note that Ghana once had rich forest cover stretching from the highlands of the Ashanti to the Western Regions. My Brother just talked about the Afadjato, where we have enormous forest cover in that area. But what we are seeing today is our rivers turning brown due to illegal activities in our forest resources and along our river bodies. Our forest reserves are being evaded and our biodiversity is disappearing. That is very serious, and it is important that on such a day, Mr Speaker, we draw attention to it.

Mr Speaker, it is not an environmental crisis alone. It is now at the height of a national security threat: if we are losing our water bodies and forests, we are primarily losing our lives and our existence as a people. And that is a national security threat. It is important that we proceed with these matters and ensure we enforce our laws.

Mr Speaker, let us be very candid. We have seen several initiatives over the years. We can talk about the Ghana Forest Plantation Strategy. That is from 2016 to 2040. We can also speak of the Green Ghana Initiative, which has now been rebranded as Tree for Life. These initiatives are right; they are good. They are important, but they should not only remain on paper. They should be used to enforce and restore our forest cover. We cannot be going about planting trees in the morning and doing *galamsey* in the night. The failure of enforcement is very critical.

Mr Speaker, the Minister talked about the Conference of Parties (COP). It is used as one way to make an absolute report on the progress that is being made by member countries, whereas the greatest challenges that these countries or these environmental communities are facing will be addressed. Mr Speaker, the current threat to our forest cover is illegal mining activities, and those are the things that we must be bold enough to address. We cannot always go about talking about programmes or commemorating events. But we must have the political will to deal with the issues that we seek to talk about. This is not the time for us to let this day remain as one of the days on our calendar, where we come, commemorate, talk, or stress on the issues, and go out there having ceremonies to commemorate. The political will must be there. The enforcement must be there.

We must not lose sight of the fact that if we fail today to address the issues that are confronting us with the degradation

of our forest reserves, Mr Speaker, later generations will not talk about us as leaders. We may have held political positions, we may have held positions of authority, but they will talk of us as a failed generation who did not honour the pledge of nature to mankind.

I will conclude by telling the Hon Minister to walk the talk and let us save our environment and our forest. I thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Collins Dauda?

Alhaji Collins Dauda (NDC — Asutifi South): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this important Statement delivered by the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources.

Mr Speaker, it is true that our forest cover is diminishing and at a very fast rate. It is difficult to stop the rate at which the forest cover is diminishing because we live in a country where, if we want to build, the forest suffers. If we want to construct roads, the forest suffers. If we want to mine, the same. If we want to farm to provide food for ourselves, the forest suffers. So it is a difficult situation to deal with.

Mr Speaker, when the country decided to put some forests under reservation, the population at the time was very small. Therefore, a large chunk of our forest was put under reservation, leaving a very large area for farming purposes. That is what is called the off-reserve areas. And this could contain us

because we were dependent on the off-reserve areas for most of our things without thinking of touching the forest reserve. In fact, at the time, if anybody wanted to enter the forest, that person needed to take a permit from the forestry officer to be able to access the forest, even to collect leaves. And they helped the Forestry Commission to protect and manage the reserves for us.

Mr Speaker, today, the communities along these forests, which were villages, have become urban towns. The off-reserve areas that they were dependent on can no longer support them. But they must eat.

2:38 p.m.

So what they do is that they encroach on the forest reserve. Like it happens in any part of the world, when the forest is dwindling, what you do is that, because it is a renewable natural resource, you go into tree planting. That should be the focus.

But Mr Speaker, everybody in this Chamber supports tree planting. Every government that has ever been in this country, has come with one programme or the other to plant trees, to enrich the forest. But what do we see?

In 2010, when I had the privilege of serving this country as a Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, I also made a similar Statement in this Chamber and my Colleagues have equally made similar Statements. But the forests keep going down. So, the only way to go, is to plant. If we make a

conscious effort to plant, we would recover our forests. Otherwise, let us forget about it.

Mr Speaker, every year, during Budget reading, we provide sums of monies to support plantation development in the country. At the end of the year, during the review, one would realise that if GH¢10.00 was allocated for plantation development, the maximum released for tree planting would be about GH¢4.00. So, we speak passionately about tree planting, but we are sluggish towards our tree planting efforts.

If we ask The Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to complain, he would complain about resources. And if you take —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you have one more minute.

Alhaji Dauda: Mr Speaker, we all need to focus on how we can provide enough money, for the Minister to be able to embark on tree planting. Let us prioritise tree planting and plantation development. If we have forests, the benefits are enormous, particularly, in this area where our youth are looking for jobs.

Plantation development can provide a lot of opportunities for our youth. So, the Minister for Finance has to be spoken to, so that in the Budget that would be presented in November, he would provide a huge sum of money to the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to embark on plantation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Kwaku Ampratwum-Sarpong?

Mr Kwaku Ampratwum-Sarpong (NPP — Mampong): Thank you, Mr Speaker for giving me the opportunity to contribute to the discussion on the table, making special reference to the Statement that was made by the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources and the Acting Minister for Environment, Science, and Technology.

I was with the Minister this morning when we went to the Achimota Forest to celebrate the day. I was extremely happy because I love nature, forest and greenery. Where I come from which is my Constituency, it is a transition between the savannah and the forest belt. When I was growing up, a greater part of the Constituency was a forest.

Now, 50 years down the line, there has been a big change. Savannah is seriously encroaching on the forest areas in my Constituency. I have seen the devastating effect that it has brought to bear on the Constituency landscape and to the constituents. So, it is good that we have a day like this where we celebrate and encourage citizens to join in preserving nature, trees and the greens. The forest, as we all know, is of great importance to all of us.

Principally, through the greenery, specifically trees, we get our oxygen and oxygen is life. So, when we link the tree with life, we are linking the tree with the provision of oxygen. If we maintain our forest, we are also fighting climate change. We all know the devastating

effect that climate change has had on mankind, on our lives and our future.

Promoting it also gives support to biodiversity thus plant and animal activities, which is of great importance to our living as human beings. At the same time, when we have the greenery, it protects our rivers. It gives shade and prevents the rivers from drying up very fast. We all know the importance of the rivers.

Apart from the forest providing us with food, medicine and helping with our livelihood, in Ghana, there has been a serious attack on the forest, that is where my concern is, the river bodies. What is happening with the river bodies? The attack of *galamsey*. What is happening in our forest reserves? The attack of the *galamseymen*, the illegal miners. It becomes so important that with the advent of *galamsey* and the activities of illegal small-scale mining, our environment is under attack. Our tomorrow is under attack. Our rivers are under attack.

It is my prayer that this Government and especially the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources pay serious and particular attention in addressing the attacks that are happening in our forest reserves. There is no point paying lip service that we are working on it, coming up with innovative and creative ideas, when nothing really is happening. But everything seems to be going down.

My good Friend the Minister is somebody I like from the other Side.
[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker.]

Minister, you are my good Friend and I like you.

[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker.]

So please —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Side?

2:48 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the comment from Mr Ampratwum cannot be allowed. He has to withdraw. It breaches Order 93(5). He is privileged to comment on the Statement made by a Member or Minister. But in doing so, he must not say things that will provoke debate. He ought not to do that. He should withdraw and apologise.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, I checked with the Hon Ampratwum-Sarpong, and I am sure that this is a matter he is willing to prove. I am also aware that the same thing is happening in the hometown of the Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources and that of the house, just in the area of the President.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, the statement he made is to the effect that—

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I withdraw. Let us not belabour. I am saying that I have withdrawn. In reference to the point I made, I have withdrawn, but let me quote what he said—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry Ahmed, with all due respect, I gave you the opportunity to comment on the Statement and you decided to yield.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, respectfully, I am in Leadership. It is a matter that has to do with my right—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You agreed to take two from each Side and then the Leadership and I have taken two from here. I came to you as a Leader and you decided to yield so you do not have a right to comment. Your right to comment has been given out. The issue we can deal with is whether it is a matter of fact that— If not, Hon Ampratwum-Sarpong, I will urge you to have that statement withdrawn.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, so let me take the step.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry Ahmed, you are not the maker of that statement.

Mr Ampratwum-Sarpong: Mr Speaker, before I come to the substantive advice that you have given me, let me just make a small comment about it. The Ankobra River—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Ampratwum-Sarpong, I gave you the opportunity to do the needful. We are all Members of Parliament. We should be guided as to how we speak against each other regarding issues of our constituencies.

Mr Ampratwum-Sarpong: Mr Speaker, let me modify my statement.

Some Hon Members: Withdraw!

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, with all due respect to the statement made by Hon Ampratwum-Sarpong that—is accordingly ordered to be expunged from the record as if it does not exist.

We are all Members of Parliament. We should be courteous as to how we speak against each other. The statement is expunged.

Mr Ampratwum-Sarpong: I do not need to withdraw—but you have expunged it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leadership?

The statement is expunged. It is no longer in the record.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, he mentioned my name.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is no longer in the record so how will you be responding to what is no longer in the record?

Hon Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, the statement is expunged and it does not exist.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I yield the role to the Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources.

Alhaji Yusif Sulemana (NDC — Bole Bamboi): Mr Speaker, I am very grateful for this opportunity. First of all, let me thank the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources for being a very responsible Minister. He has come here this afternoon to remind us of a very important global activity. So, we need to eulogise him for that stewardship.

Mr Speaker, the theme for this year's International Day of Forests is "Forests and Economy" and many relevant points have been made in terms of its economic benefits, job creation and all of that.

Mr Speaker, I have listened to my Colleagues, and I think that days like this should be used in providing solutions rather than lamentations and accusations. This is a House of records and so when we speak, we must come with facts. If there is any government that is noted on record, and I will make reference to the report of Prof Frimpong-Boateng, if we advert our minds to that report, those on this Side will not have the moral right to even talk on issues of *galamsey*.

Mr Speaker, we are in a situation where the New Patriotic Party (NPP) administration bequeathed to us—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, you are reminded of Standing Order 93(5). So, you need to make sure that your comment does not generate into a debate.

Alhaji Y. Sulemana: Mr Speaker, I am guided and thank you for the direction. The John Dramani Mahama-

led administration inherited a situation where out of about 288 forest reserves, 44 were tampered with between the period of His Excellency Nana Akufo-Addo—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I admonish you, Order 93(5).

Alhaji Y. Sulemana: Mr Speaker, I take the cue once again. I am saying that we inherited a situation where about 44 of our forest reserves were tampered with where we have *galamsey* activities going on. Out of the 44, nine were completely taken over. This is what we inherited—

Mr Shaib — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I recognise Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib on his feet.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, as per your direction, he is still not listening. I come under Order 93(5) to say that all the comments canvassed by him, the last part of his comments, are not a true reflection of the situation.

Mr Speaker, when I said same, you asked me to withdraw. If he cannot provide evidence to the effect of what he is saying now, we should have that expunged and he should apologise. It is not part of the Statement of the Minister.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Sulemana, be guided accordingly.

Alhaji Y. Sulemana: Mr Speaker, I am saying to you that we have 288 forest reserves and out of what we inherited 44

of them were tampered with illegal mining activities; that is a fact and this happened between a certain period. We are saying that out of the 44, nine of those forest reserves were no-go areas. That is a fact and this is not the first time we are saying it on this Floor. It is found in all instances where the Minister has spoken, and it is also found in the Message on the State of the Nation, 2025.

Mr Speaker, when we talk about *galamsey* and the headquarters of *galamsey*, it is very obvious that he cannot—

Mr Speaker, let me tell you that for the records, there is no single forest reserve in the Bole Bamboi Constituency that has been destroyed. Let me also put on record that there is no river body in the Bole Bamboi Constituency that has been destroyed. So, if they make a statement that *galamsey* activities are taking place in the Bole Bamboi Constituency and that that should be an issue, let us advert our minds to the Eastern Region, the Ashanti Region and the Western Region.

2:58 p.m.

These are areas where rivers have been tampered with and we are concentrating on these areas to ensure that all these rivers that have been tampered with are brought back to life. I thought that we should have been asking ourselves, as Members of Parliament, how many trees have we have planted in a year? How many trees have we encouraged somebody to plant? These

are the things that we should be talking about, rather than lamenting—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have gradually come to an end of that Statement. There is another Statement on the essence of *Eid-ul-Fitr*, to the peaceful co-existence and development in Ghana. Fortunately, the maker of the Statement is here. Hon Baba Jamal Mohammed Ahmed, MP for Ayawaso East Constituency. You have the Floor.

The Essence of the Celebration of Eid-ul-Fitr by the Muslim Community in Ghana

Mr Baba Jamal Mohammed Ahmed (NDC — Ayawaso East): Mr Speaker, I humbly rise to make a Statement on the essence of the celebration of *Eid-ul-Fitr* by the Muslim community in Ghana and the world at large, but permit me to greet you with Islamic greetings, *Assalamu alaikum*.

Some Hon Members: *Alaikum as-salam*.

Mr Ahmed: Peace be unto this House. Today marks the last day of 30 days of fasting by Muslims worldwide, including our Muslim compatriots in Ghana. It has been a period of self-denial of food and worldly pleasures by Muslims, myself inclusive.

Mr Speaker, after fasting over the period of 30 days, Allah has ordained *Eid-ul-Fitr* for all Muslims for merrymaking, brotherly love and total submission to the will of Almighty

Allah. In Ghana, the celebrations of this festival start tomorrow with massive prayers in all Muslim communities across Ghana, especially in the Zongos, where we have large concentrations of Muslims. With the national celebrations and prayers at Independence Square to be led by the National Chief Imam, Dr Sheikh Nuhu Sharubutu.

The essence of this festival is to bring families and friends together as Islam teaches us to ensure every member of the community, be they Muslims or not, to be happy, well catered for and shown love. This celebration teaches us peaceful coexistence and tolerance, which are essential tools for national development. It teaches Muslims to reach out to other people in their neighbourhood and make peace with all mankind.

Mr Speaker, as Muslims celebrate *Eid-ul-Fitr*, the lessons learned during the fasting period must reflect in our daily lives as Ghanaians. The spirit of *Eid-ul-Fitr* is love for one another. Let all Ghanaians, not only Muslims, be our brother's keeper. One of the famous sayings of the Prophet Muhammad, found in Al-Shaykh Buhari is:

“La yu’minu ahadukum hatta yuhibba li akhihi ma yuhibbu li nafsih”

Mr Speaker, translated, “none of you is a true believer of Islam unless you desire for your brother or sister what you desire for yourself”.

Some Hon Members: Repeat.

Mr Ahmed: Therefore, a Muslim is a true believer of Islam only and when he desires for another person, Muslim or non-Muslim, what they desire for themselves. As celebrated world-wide, in Ghana, the festival is marked with cultural display of chiefs and people of different tribal and ethnic back-grounds, especially in the Zongo's and in Nima city in particular, different tribal groups led by their various chiefs organise processions on the streets to thank Allah for his message throughout the year. It is a great thing to witness this procession nicknamed *Kashi Kashika*, "shake and dance" on the streets of Nima. I take this opportunity, Mr Speaker, to invite all Ghanaians to witness this special procession on the street of Nima this year on the day of *Eid-ul-Fitr*, which is tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, another significant aspect of the celebration of *Eid-ul-Fitr* is that it brings families and tribes together to appreciate each other and to live in peace.

Almighty Allah states in the Holy Quran chapter 49 verse 13:

"Yaa ayyuhan naasu innaa khalaqnaakum min zakarin wa unsaa wa ja'alnaakum shu'ooban wa qabaaa'ila lita'aarafoo; inna akramakum 'indallaahi atqaakum; innallaaha 'aleemun khabeer."

We translate, "O humanity, indeed we created you from a male and a female and made you into peoples and tribes, so that you may get to know one another. Surely the most noble of you in the sight

of Allah is the most righteous among you. Allah is truly all-knowing and aware". So, in Islam, tribes are for the purposes of identification and cultural unity, but not division among mankind. So, the celebration of *Eid-ul-Fitr* offers us the opportunity to come together as one people in different tribes. That spirit of unity in diversity is what has kept together Zongo people and Muslims in general for many years.

Mr Speaker, by the kind courtesy of President Mahama and his government, and the approval of this august House, Muslims in Ghana, and for that matter all Ghanaians, enjoy two holidays on the occasion of *Eid-ul-Fitr*, which we are very grateful for as Muslims. This allows Muslims to celebrate the festival in peace and joyful mood. It allows families to come together to spend time together. Tribes and groups come together to celebrate their culture and heritage. It brings joy and great times to Muslims and Ghanaians as a whole, and this brings out the true Ghanaian religious mix and tolerance that sets us aside from other countries in the world.

Mr Speaker, permit me to use this opportunity to admonish all and sundry who, out of ignorance of our history, as a country erroneously see people living in our Zongo's and largely Muslim communities as aliens and foreigners, to reorient themselves and see all persons irrespective of their tribe, religion, creed, or name as Ghanaians once they satisfy the constitutional criteria of the Republic of Ghana. Let all Ghanaians know that it is not the tribe of a person or his religion, creed, or name that makes him a

Ghanaian, but it is the laws of Ghana that makes a person a Ghanaian.

Finally, Mr Speaker, the Prophet Mohammed, *sallallahu alayhi wa sallam*, admonished all Muslims to be generous on the day of *Eid-ul-Fitr*. Muslims must be tolerant and peace makers, patriotic and serve their country, in this case Ghana, with all their heart. We as Muslims and indeed all Ghanaians must understand that rights go with responsibilities and we must all be law-abiding as dictated by the celebration of *Eid-ul-Fitr*. Muslims must live with other people from other religions in peace and harmony. They must sing the praises of Almighty Allah from dawn to dusk on Eid day. We must pray for the continuous blessings of peace in our country, even as we celebrate *Eid-ul-Fitr*.

3:08 p.m.

I wish all Ghanaians a happy *Eid-ul-Fitr* and a blessed new year. I thank you, Mr Speaker. *As-salamu alaykum*.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah (NPP — Okaikwei Central): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Let me thank the Hon Member of Parliament for Ayawaso East for this very important Statement before this very important celebration comes tomorrow, *Inshallah*.

Mr Speaker, I would like to use this opportunity to wish the National Chief Imam, Dr Sheikh Usmanu Nuhu Sharubutu, my constituent, my father, and someone the whole country loves and adore, and also Sheikh

Umar Ibrahim of Abeka who leads the Ahlussuna Wal Jamaa sect of this country.

Mr Speaker, the Prophet Mohammed, *Sallallahu alaihi wasallam*, peace be upon him, preaches peace, love for one another and to be very modest during this celebration. It is for a reason that for some time now, the Ramadan period has coincided with the Lent period by the Christians. It is important for us to know and appreciate as a country that we should live together as one people, love one another, celebrate Christmas, Easter, Ramadan or Salah together in peace and in oneness, and ensure that we all achieve the goals of this country as brothers.

On this auspicious day and on this very important day, following the maiden Statement made by the Member of Parliament for Ayawaso East after his election, let me say a big 'thank you' to all the Muslim communities in and around New Fadama, Abeka, Apenkwa, the whole country and to the Leader of the House who is a Muslim. I wish him and the Muslim Brothers and Sisters in the Chamber a happy Salah. May Allah bless us all.

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by my Brother, Hon Baba Jamal on the *Eid-ul-Fitr*.

Eid-ul-Fitr is a celebration by the Muslim Ummah after a 29 or 30 day fast. Many a time we observe this fast from morning, that is before 6 a.m., when we

take sahur. Some of us do not eat in the morning. We observe the fast until evening and that is after 6 p.m. This is done for either 29 or 30 days, which is accepted by the Almighty Allah. Mr Speaker, during the fast in the day, we neither eat nor drink and neither does one have to get into any nocturnal activities, married or unmarried. We try as much as we can to abstain from anything that would destroy our fast.

Mr Speaker, during the fast, we are supposed to be more peaceful than ever, prayerful, asking for forgiveness, not for ourselves alone but for everyone, because at least we have our children, grandchildren, relatives, colleagues and associates. Prayer is very important when we are observing our fast. Under the circumstance, women that are still menstruating do not observe the fast, but they are supposed to fast and “pay” for the number of days that they would have menstruated. So those that would menstruate maybe four days, one week, ten days, they will have to “pay” after that because they were not allowed to fast.

Mr Speaker, Muslims who are not well will not fast. When we say those who are not well, it depends on factors. Those who are not well just for a period would have to repay when they are well. But for those that are so unwell or unhealthy that cannot fast at all, they have to pay by offering some quantities of food to especially the poor and needy. Those who are so seriously sick and cannot afford to offer anything are not obligated to pay anything once they do not have it.

The Islamic religion and for that matter, we Muslims are enjoined not to segregate, discriminate, judge, or try in any way to malign anybody because we are not the Almighty Allah. We do not judge, and we cannot tell. We cannot judge anybody because of religion, ethnicity, tribe, race or gender. With this, the religion enjoins everyone to accept every individual as he or she is, and when we are praying, we pray for everybody.

With the celebration which most of us, especially in Ghana, will be undertaking tomorrow, Muslims are supposed to congregate at various places to say the Eid prayer. For those who are not able to go, it does not mean that if they do not go to the Eid grounds, they cannot pray their two Rakah at home. Mr Speaker, whatever we may have tomorrow to celebrate—

Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah (NPP — Manhyia South): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I commend Hon Baba Jamal Mohammed Ahmed, until recently, “His Excellency”, for making such an insightful Statement.

There could not have been a better time for such a Statement, inspiring unity among the people of this Republic, particularly because he himself has been a victim of circumstance and for that reason, he is in a position to preach about unity. So, I commend him for preaching unity in this country.

What I found very thought-provoking and insightful is the third sentence of the fourth paragraph of his

Statement. Mr Speaker, with your liberty, I quote:

“None of you is a true believer of Islam unless you desire for your brother or sister what you desire for yourself.”

It is very instructive. It is useful learning that we do not wish for others what we do not wish for ourselves. So, we must all learn from this. We should wish for others the good we wish for ourselves, and pray to avert the evil we do not wish for ourselves.

3:18 p.m.

The Eid, in my humble view, is a very good moment for me, because my constituency has a very significant Muslim population, the Afia Kobi electoral area, which is popularly called Alabar. Mr Speaker, I wish all the Muslims in my constituency a Happy Eid. At this point, I would also want to pray that the good Lord receives into the bosom of Abraham, all those who lost their lives in the course of their fasting.

In my constituency, on a fine Sunday, I decided to break the fast with some of my Muslim friends at Afia Kobi electoral area. The next dawn, we were unfortunately informed of the demise of one of the gentlemen, a polling station chairman, a unit committee member, and a very good friend of mine, who was part of the event that day. His name was Sadiq Abu Bakar, and I pray that the good Lord keeps his soul in the bosom of Abraham.

In conclusion, another part of his Statement that I find very interesting has to do with:

“Oh humanity, indeed, we created you from a male and female, and made you into people and tribes, so that you may get to know one another...”

Let us get to know one another and be united, irrespective of political divide, and where we stand, even within our own political party. Let us love one another, and not be antagonistic, and form committees, and sign letters against people. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Alhaji Yusif Sulemana (NDC — Bole Bamboi): Mr Speaker, I am very grateful. Let me welcome my Brother with the very words he has used in welcoming us. So, I say:

“ay altariqat alati tatlubuha binafsika. alsalam ealaykum warahmat allah wabarakatuhu. 'iinaha nafs altariqat alati tutlub biha dhalika. alsalam ealaykum warahmat allah wabarakatuh ealaa alnabii.”

To wit: the same way he has asked for Allah's peace and blessings be upon us, is the same way I am asking that Allah's blessings and peace be upon the Prophet.

Mr Speaker, this Statement is well researched, and touches the very important ingredients that are supposed to be touched in matters like this. Mr

Speaker, Eid ul-Fitr marks the end of the month of Ramadan, so it is a period when all Muslims will come together to celebrate and commemorate the 29 or 30 days that they have fasted. Indeed, it is a period for us to show love to each other and beyond. It is a period where we have to give out *Zakat ul-Fitr*. The *Zakat ul-Fitr* is a special sadaqah or zakah that we give to our neighbours. It should be a day when everybody around us will celebrate. It should be a day when we are eating, nobody should be hungry, and it is a day we have to show love. That is why I am very happy my Brother mentioned the appropriate Quranic verses. In the Quran, chapter 49:13, it says:

“ya 'ayuha alnaas 'iinaa khalaqnakum min dhakar wa'unthaa wajaernalakum shueuban waqabayil litaearafuu 'iina 'akramakum eind allah 'atqakum 'iinah ealim allkhabir.”

To wit: O mankind, indeed, we have created you from male and female and made you peoples and tribes that you may know one another. The essence of that is for you to be able to identify yourself, is for you to be able to know yourself.

This is very important for us today in Ghana. Let us not allow religion to divide us, and we should not allow politics to divide us. After all, when it comes to religion, the Quran says: *“lakum dinukum wali din”*

To wit: Unto your religion and unto me, my religion, the person who will judge is Allah. Again, the Quran says: “لَا

رُسُلِهِ مِنْ أَحَدٍ بَيْنَ نَفَرٍ”. To wit: Do not bring about distinction among my prophet. So, all Muslims believe in Jesus Christ, so we are not supposed to bring about a division between him and his followers, and that of the Prophet Muhammad and his followers. It is very important for us, and we expect all of us to come together and show love. After all, the person who judges is Allah.

So, I want to use this platform to call on all Muslims who are celebrating Eid ul-Fitr tomorrow to do it with humility. A situation where we see our brothers riding on motorbikes and over-celebrating should be a thing of the past. This is a day to show love and share what we have. I do not expect to see our brothers riding bicycles and motorbikes in a way and manner that will not bring peace. I use this opportunity on behalf of the Muslim Caucus of Parliament to wish all Muslims in Ghana, and in particular my constituency, Eid Mubarak. May the Almighty Allah give us the blessings of the man that we have observed. May the blessings be attached to all of us, whether a Muslim or a Christian. May the Almighty Allah bless our President, the Speaker, the Legislature, and everybody in this country, so that at the end of the day, we will be able to develop a nation that others will admire. With this, I say: *Wa'alaikumussalam warahmatullahi wabarakatuh*. To wit: may Allah's peace and blessings be upon all of you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leadership?

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity.

Let me particularly commend the former High Commissioner to Nigeria, H.E. Alhaji Baba Jamal Ahmed, a Friend of the Minority. [*Hear! Hear!*].

Mr Speaker, against the backdrop that Ghana is practicing religious pluralism, we have the Chief Imam, who is also very close to Rev Father Campbell, in my constituency. I am a proud Ghanaian. Hon Baba Jamal Ahmed made some very important submissions, and it behoves us, and me in particular, to call on him to understand that during this fasting period, there was one thing we asked for, that our sins be forgiven. Mr Speaker, he asked that Allah should create in us a clean heart, renew our spirits, and forgive our sins and the sins of other Members.

Mr Speaker, I am making a personal and passionate appeal to Hon Alhaji Baba Jamal Ahmed to forgive the regional Majority Caucus Members, the 16 Chairpersons, who wrote the letter asking for his disqualification. Hon Baba Jamal Ahmed, may Allah touch your heart to forgive every Member of the Regional Caucus, and the whole Majority Caucus, led by the Majority Leader, for rejecting you. In fact, he should forgive Jubilee House, too, for coming against him. Hon Baba Jamal Ahmed, let me refer to his own saying—

3:28 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry Ahmed, sometimes, I believe strongly you do certain things deliberately, because I will not doubt your knowledge of the rules.

Yes, Hon Dafeamekpor?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Hon Second Deputy Minority Whip, my Brother, is on his feet and has said very unparliamentary things. Those things he has said against the Chairpersons of the Regional Caucus of the Majority Side, and the Majority Leader, are unparliamentary. They cannot stay in our records. He needs to withdraw them and apologise. Nobody from the Majority Side wrote to reject Hon Baba Jamal. [*Uproar*] He is not communicating properly. So, he should withdraw, because those things he has said offend Order 93(5). His comments are provoking debate so he should withdraw them. He knows what to do. He is a leader of this House.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I thank my Brother for bringing this to my notice. I also ask for forgiveness if in my acts or omissions, I may have stepped on a toe. I am using this platform and this Statement so that they will not take me to the Committee of Privileges and Immunities. [*Hear! Hear!*] Mr Speaker, it is very crucial that we forgive ourselves. And this is the opportune time for us to ask for forgiveness.

Mr Speaker, let me refer to a line in the Statement by Hon Baba Jamal that is most critical. He said:

“None of you is a true believer of Islam unless you desire for your brother or sister what you desire for yourself”.

Simplicita; love your neighbour as yourself.

Mr Speaker, this is Baba Jamal. He has been a Member of Parliament before. He was only praying to come back and join his own Colleagues. And all he found was action *nkotee*. Mr Speaker, we are using this platform to ask that we stay united. Let us forgive ourselves. Let peace reign. Whether you are NDC or NPP, whether you are from Bole or Chorkor, we are all one people. Whether you support one parliamentary candidate or presidential candidate, please let us know that it is for us to remain united.

Mr Speaker, let me take this opportunity to wish all Muslims in Weija-Gbawe, especially the Imams, and across Ghana and the world, a happy Eid. May God bless us all.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Member for Ayawaso East has broken the ice and made his first formal Statement on the Floor of the House to mark this very important festival on the Islamic calendar. Let me acknowledge the contributions that have been made by Colleagues who have already emphasised the importance of the Eid to Muslims and to the rest of humanity.

Mr Speaker, Muslims in this country have made a lot of progress, especially under the Government of the National Democratic Congress. In our 2024 electioneering campaign, we promised the Muslim community that if we won the election, we would add one

additional public holiday to the Muslim community. And we have done it. So, for this Eid, Muslims are going to have cumulatively four days in a row. Tomorrow, Friday, will be a public holiday. Saturday and Sunday are already holidays. And Monday, they will enjoy a holiday.

The NDC knew very well how Muslims struggle to fast for 30 days, especially the last 10 days, when they would stay throughout the night, praying. So, it becomes difficult if you give them just one holiday because they need time to prepare for the Eid. Against objection and opposition, from people that are known in this Chamber, we on this Side weathered the storm and passed the legislation which institutionalised a second holiday for Muslims. We are very proud today that this has come to stay and we know that Muslims appreciate the National Democratic Congress. That is not all. Muslims are making progress. This year, the Hajj fee is affordable. It has been reduced, and Muslims would enjoy the Hajj better than they did last time.

Mr Speaker, I want to state that, no matter what they say of Hon Baba Jamal, he will never be a member on their Side. Put an issue to a vote before this House, and no matter what they say, Hon Baba Jamal will vote for the NDC. Hon Baba Jamal will remain a proud member on this Side of the House. Nothing that they say would convert him to a member of the NPP. So, they should stop deceiving themselves. They should stop feeling that they can co-opt him because he will never be a member of the NPP. He will

never vote for NPP. Even when he does not have a use for his vote, he will not give it to the NPP. *[Hear! Hear!]* So, they should not waste their time.

As for this Side of the House, I can assure them, we have no issue with Hon Baba Jamal. The position taken by this Side of the House, following those incidents, are principled positions which did not respect persons and that is what Islam teaches everyone.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, there is an indication that your time is up.

3:38 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I do not know when we started timing Leaders. But let me conclude by saying that we thank our Colleague for the Statement and to wish all Muslims a happy Eid celebration. And to also caution our brothers and sisters that they should celebrate in modesty. The level of excitement that we see sometimes when our young people ride bikes and horses, in the celebration of the Eid, can sometimes be scary and in some instances, have led to fatalities.

We are praying that tomorrow's Eid and all the festivities during the celebration of the Eid will be done with modesty having regard to the safety of everyone who is participating in the celebration. I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Statements time has ended.

Majority Side, any indication?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, indeed we want to take the item numbered 9, that is the Report of the Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority? We are done with the item numbered 8, so we are moving to the item numbered 9.

Mr Shaib: Yes, Mr Speaker, I have seen that the two powerful Leaders are engaging. That is a good thing. So while we allow them to engage and come back, I think that is the best way to go.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So as a matter of fact, as they are engaging, the actual item is the item numbered 10. This is the procedural one, so we can be looking at it pending the outcome of their engagement and that will inform us as to whether we should take the item numbered 10.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, that is all right.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Before then, let me use the opportunity to acknowledge the presence of students from Radiant D/A Basic School, led by Richard Dickson, a teacher. They are from Ajumako/Enyan/Essiam and they are 136 in number.

[Pupils of Radiant D/A Basic School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We also have Glory Praise Academy, led by Mr

Jacob Mensah, a teacher. They are from Kpone Katamanso and they are 55 in number. Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome them to Parliament and urge them to have a fruitful visit. Kindly resume your seats.

[Pupils of Glory Praise Academy were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairperson of the Committee?

MOTIONS

Suspension of Order 104(1)

Chairperson of the Committee (Alhaji Collins Dauda): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provisions of Standing Order 104(1) which require that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the Motion is given, the Motion for the adoption of the Report of the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources on the Mining Lease Agreement Between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources) and Barari DV Ghana Limited for the mining of Lithium and other minerals at Mankessim (42.63 km²) in the Mfantseman Municipality of the Central Region may be *moved* today.

Second Deputy Majority Whip (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leadership, I saw you engaging.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the engagement has been fruitful. So, we will take the Motion numbered 10.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairperson of the Committee.

Mining Lease Agreement between GoG and Barari DV Ghana Limited

Chairperson of the Committee (Alhaji Collins Dauda): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources on the Mining Lease Agreement Between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources) and Barari DV Ghana Limited for the mining of Lithium and other minerals at Mankessim (42.63 km²) in the Mfantseman Municipality of the Central Region.

Mr Speaker, in doing so, I present your Committee's report and I crave your indulgence to read some parts of the observations and ask the *Hansard* to capture it as having been fully read.

Introduction

On 19th December, 2025, the Hon Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah (MP), pursuant to Article 268 of the 1992 Constitution and Section 5(4) of the Minerals and Mining Act, 2006 (Act 703), presented to Parliament the Mining Lease Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (Represented by the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources) and Barari DV Ghana Limited for the Mining of Lithium and other Minerals at Mankessim (42.63 km²) in the Mfantseman Municipality in the Central Region.

Subsequently, Mr Speaker referred the Agreement to the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources for consideration and report pursuant to the Standing Orders of the House.

Deliberations

The Committee met and considered the Agreement with the Hon Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, Mr Yusif Sulemana (MP) and officials from the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources, Minerals Commission and the Environmental Protection Authority (EPA).

The Committee also wrote to and received a written response from the Minerals Income Investment Fund (MIIF) in relation to the Agreement.

The Committee caused a publication of the referral in newspapers of

nationwide circulation, inviting memoranda from the public.

The Committee expresses its profound gratitude to the Hon Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources and the team of officials for attending upon and assisting the Committee in the deliberations.

The Committee also expresses appreciation to the stakeholders and members of the public who presented memoranda and/or made *viva voce* submissions to the Committee to assist in the consideration of the Agreement.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to and/or was guided by the following documents during the deliberations:

- i. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament, 2024;
- iii. The Minerals and Mining Act, 2006 (Act 703);
- iv. The Minerals and Mining (Amendment) Act, 2015 (Act 900);
- v. The Minerals and Mining (Amendment) Act, 2019 (Act 995);
- vi. The Ghana Integrated Aluminium Development Corporation Act, 2018 (Act 976);

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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> vii. The Minerals and Mining (Compensation and Resettlement) Regulations, 2012 (L.I. 2175); viii. The Minerals and Mining (Health, Safety and Technical) Regulations, 2012 (L.I. 2182); ix. The Minerals and Mining (General) Regulations, 2012 (L.I. 2173); x. The Minerals and Mining (Licensing) Regulations, 2012 (L.I. 2176); xi. The Minerals and Mining (Local Content and Local Participation) Regulations, 2020 (L.I. 2431); xii. Letter from the Institute of Economic Affairs dated 19th July, 2024; and xiii. The Supreme Court decision in the case of <i>Republic v High Court, (General Jurisdiction 6), Accra; ex parte Attorney-General (Exton Cubic – Interested Party)</i> [Unreported, Civil Motion No. J5/40/2018] dated 31st July, 2019. | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> Traditional Area and Abura Traditional Area; iii. Assembly Members Representing the Affected Communities Within the Ewoyaa Lithium Project Area; iv. Ewoyaa Citizens Association; v. Alliance for Empowering Rural Communities (AERC); vi. Green Africa Youth Organisation (GAYO); vii. Institute of Economic Affairs (IEA); viii. Friends of the Nation (based in Adiembra, Sekondi); ix. Mass Action for Sustainable Development in Africa (MASDA); x. IMANI Africa; xi. Natural Resources Governance Institute (NRGI); and xii. Various Individuals. |
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The Committee also received memoranda from the following:

- i. Divisional Chiefs and Odikro of Project-Affected Communities of Ewoyaa Lithium Project;
- ii. Paramount Chiefs of Nkusukum Traditional Area, Mankessim

Background

In 2012, Barari DV Ghana Limited, a subsidiary of Atlantic Lithium Limited (ALL), started operations in Ghana when it was first granted a reconnaissance licence for exploration at the Ewoyaa concession in the Mfantseman Municipality of the Central Region.

The reconnaissance licence was converted into a prospecting licence in 2018. Following a successful exploration resulting in the discovery of high lithium in commercial quantities, the Company applied for a mining lease for the exploitation of the mineral.

Government, determined to ensure that the exploitation of the mineral should increasingly benefit the people of Ghana, developed a policy which Cabinet approved in October 2025 for the exploitation, management and utilisation of the country's green minerals. The Government has further decided to treat the exploitation of this mineral and other green minerals differently from other minerals being exploited in the country. After Cabinet's approval, the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources entered into further negotiations with Barari DV Ghana Limited for the grant of a mining lease that conforms with the laws of Ghana and international best practices.

It has therefore become imperative that the mining lease be ratified by Parliament in accordance with Article 268 (1) of the 1992 Constitution and Section 5(4) of the Minerals and Mining Act, 2006 (Act 703), as amended.

Views of Stakeholders

The Committee, in its deliberations on the Agreement, took into consideration the various memoranda submitted by chiefs, assemblymen, think tanks and individuals, among others. The stakeholders were also permitted to make in-person presentations to the

Committee prior to the Agreement being withdrawn on the 11th day of November 2025 and re-laid on the 19th day of December 2025.

The views of the stakeholders were varied. While some agreed that the Agreement be recommended for approval by Parliament, others suggested that the Lease agreement be modified before approval by Parliament.

The Committee particularly noted that most of the concerns raised have been addressed in the Agreement. A number of those concerns relate to matters contained in paragraph 7 (Observations) of this report.

There was also a strong suggestion that Ghana should own its minerals and adopt a State-owned approach to the development of the lithium resource, moving away from the current model of granting concessions to foreign companies under royalty-based arrangements.

While not disagreeing with this suggestion, the Committee finds that it presents a proposed paradigm shift in government policy on the exploitation of minerals in the country. The Committee drew attention of the proposal to the ministry for guidance for future policy reforms.

A Brief about Lithium

Lithium is an element valuable for the production of glass, aluminium products and batteries. It is mined from ores of petalite, lepidolite, spodumene

and also subsurface brines. Lithium and other green minerals have widely been acknowledged to represent the future since they are considered the centre of the green transition.

Global decarbonisation efforts, such as the shift to electric vehicles (EVs), are in large part made possible due to lithium batteries. As a result, the demand for lithium has increased exponentially in recent years. Projections suggest that by 2030, lithium demand may surpass 2.4 million metric tons of LCE (Lithium Carbonate Equivalent [LCE], which is the amount of lithium contained in one tonne of lithium carbonate). A 2022 analysis by the McKinsey Battery Insights team projects that the entire lithium-ion (Li-ion) battery chain, from mining through recycling, could grow by over 30 percent annually from 2022 to 2030, when it would reach a value of more than \$400 billion and a market size of 4.7 Terawatt hours. Global demand for Lithium-ion batteries is expected to soar over the next decade, with the number of gigawatt hours required increasing from about 700 gigawatt hours in 2022 to around 4.7 Terawatt hours by 2030. Batteries for mobility applications such as Electric Vehicles (EVs), will account for the vast bulk of demand in 2030—about 4,300 gigawatt hours; an unsurprising trend, given the rapid growth in mobility applications.

Considering the significant deposits of hard-rock and brine lithium Ghana has, all efforts must be made to position Ghana strategically to reap the benefits from this green mineral in a more

sustainable fashion. The addition of lithium to the mineral mix in the country is expected to bring tremendous economic benefits.

The Lease Area and Tenure of the Mining Lease

The Mining Lease covers an area of 42.63 km² located at Mankessim in the Mfantseman Municipality of the Central Region.

The tenure of the mining lease is fifteen (15) years, which is renewable in accordance with the Minerals and Mining Act 2006 (Act 703).

Observations

Issues Relating to the Environment

The Committee noted that the Company was granted an environmental permit, but it has since expired and is currently awaiting renewal. The Chief Executive Officer of the Environmental Protection Authority (EPA) explained that the permit renewal process is undertaken annually and that preliminary assessments have already been conducted, with the Authority anticipating the issuance of a new permit in due course.

The Committee also noted that Clause 1(f) of the Agreement provides that:

“The Company shall not, however, conduct any operations in a reserved area, restricted area, protected area, or designated area and shall not, without the prior written consent of the Minister, conduct any operations:

- (i) Within a hundred (100) metres of any forest reserve, river, stream, building, installation, reservoir, dam, public road, railway, or area appropriated for a railway.”

Furthermore, Clause 5(a) (ii) of the Mining Lease Agreement further provides that “the Company shall ensure conservation of resources, reclamation of land and protection of the environment”.

Free Carried Interest

The Committee observed that, while Ghana has 10 per cent free carried interest in all mining companies in the country, in this agreement, government negotiated for 13 per cent.

It is provided in Clause 19(b) of the Agreement that “The Government of Ghana shall be entitled to thirteen percent (13 per cent) interest in the rights and obligations of the mineral operations of the Company as free carried interest in respect of which financial contributions shall not be paid by the Government.”

Interest of Minerals Income Investment Fund (MIIF) in the Project

The Committee noted that the Minerals Income Investment Fund (MIIF) has taken an equity interest in the parent company, Atlantic Lithium.

However, MIIF is yet to take an equity stake in the mining project. The Committee recommends that the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources

takes steps to ensure that MIIF takes the equity stake in the mining project as contemplated under the Agreement.

Taxes and Other Financial Obligations of the Company

The Committee noted that the Agreement does not grant tax waiver to the Company as the Company is expressly required to pay tax in accordance with the applicable laws of Ghana. The Company is further obligated to “pay to the Government of Ghana all other fees, levies, charges and penalties as provided under applicable Laws and Regulations”.

Again, the Company is required to pay annual ground rent to the Office of the Administrator of Stool Lands (OASL) in accordance with Section 23 of Act 703.

Furthermore, the Company is required to pay an annual mineral right fee in accordance with Section 24 of Act 703 and the applicable provisions of L.I. 2176.

Payment of Royalty

The Committee noted that the Company is required by the Agreement to pay to the Government of Ghana, royalty at the rate and in the manner prescribed by law. The royalty shall be paid to Government through the Ghana Revenue Authority.

Minerals Covered by the Agreement

The Committee noted that the authorised minerals, the subject of the

Agreement are “Lithium and other associated minerals”.

It was explained to the Committee that the associated minerals are those naturally connected with lithium such as feldspar. Therefore, the Agreement does not cover other substantive minerals for which a separate license is required from the Minister to exploit.

It is thus provided by the Agreement that the Government of Ghana may grant mineral rights to third parties to prospect for or to enter into agreements for the production of other minerals in the lease area, provided that such activity shall not unreasonably interfere with the rights of the Company under this Agreement.

In accordance with Section 15 of Act 703, Barari DV is given the first option to apply to prospect for or mine the new minerals discovered in the lease area.

Community Development Fund

Clause 3 of Schedule 2 to the Mining Lease Agreement provides that “the Company shall set aside one (1) per cent [1%] of annual revenue for a community development fund pursuant to a Community Development Agreement that shall be signed with the communities impacted by its operations.”

The Committee thus noted that the establishment of the CDF upon ratification of the Agreement and the subsequent operationalisation of the mining project would bring significant socio-economic benefits to the people of

the mine area through investments and infrastructural projects by the fund.

Preparatory discussions on the CDF have already taken place between the communities and the Company. A memorandum received from the Paramount Chiefs of Nkusukum, Mankessim, and Abura Traditional Areas states the following regarding the Community Development Fund contemplated under the Agreement:

“Our engagements with the Company have commenced toward this Fund and a framework is in draft. This Fund, projected to exceed [US\$6.0 million annually], will bring significant development to the catchment area and the Central Region. We, Nananom and community leaders, at a Community Consultative Committee (CCC) meeting, have proposed using a substantial portion of this Fund to stimulate other industries in the catchment area. The fund will also support scholarships for disadvantaged students and the development of health and education facilities.”

The memorandum from the Paramount Chiefs further indicates the following regarding ‘Infrastructural Development’:

“Though not having started operations, the Company has undertaken some local procurement and infrastructural development in our communities, showing its commitment to community development. We are informed that

the project will utilise locally-made goods and services during construction and production to promote the local economy and build capacity.”

Thus, Nananom are firmly behind the project due to the potential benefits of the project in terms of infrastructure development, local capacity building and technology transfer and generally boosting the local economy of the catchment areas.

Job Creation

The Committee noted that the project has the potential of creating about one thousand (1,000) direct mining jobs and many indirect jobs for the communities within the mine area. More than one hundred (100) youth in the mine area have already been employed, with training programmes scheduled to be undertaken upon the ratification of the Agreement by Parliament.

Compensation to Landowners

As to what was being done with regard to land access and compensation to project affected persons, the Committee was informed that the Company and the communities have established a Compensation Negotiation Committee for Crop and Land and a Resettlement Negotiation Committee for persons due for resettlement as prescribed by the Minerals and Mining Act, 2006 (Act 703) and the Minerals and Mining (Compensation and Resettlement) Regulations, 2012 (L.I. 2175).

Value Addition

The Committee noted that paragraphs (c) to (e) of Clause 1 of Schedule 2 to the Agreement provide that the Company shall establish a chemical plant for refining the concentrate in Ghana, subject to the outcome of the scoping study to be undertaken by the Company.

Where the Company is unable to establish a chemical plant, the Company shall make concentrate available to any chemical plant(s) established in Ghana for refining on terms to be agreed upon.

All by-products of the mineral, such as feldspar and kaolin, shall be sold locally and such products shall not be exported unless expressly authorised by the Minister, where there is no demand for the product in Ghana.

The Committee finds these provisions to be critical to the integrated advancement of the sector and the industrial development of the country. It is observed that this provision in the Agreement is novel as it does not exist in mining agreements in respect of other minerals mined in the country.

Local Content and Local Participation

The Committee was informed that the terms of the Agreement provide for the Company to engage expatriates, train Ghanaians and procure local goods and services for its operations in accordance with the applicable laws.

To ensure local content and local participation, Clause 4 of Schedule 2 to the Mining Lease Agreement provides that the Company or its parent Company shall list on the Ghana Stock Exchange in accordance with the Minerals and Mining (Local Content and Local Participation) Regulations, 2020 (L.I 2431).

The Committee noted that the Lease Agreement includes a strategic commitment for enhancing maritime and logistical infrastructure in the Saltpond area. The following obligations have been established:

Within six (6) months from the ratification of the Lease Agreement, the Company is required to conduct a comprehensive feasibility study. This study must evaluate the viability of constructing a jetty, barge, or mini-port system at Saltpond or an adjacent suitable location.

Should the study confirm the project's feasibility, the Company is mandated within twelve (12) months, following the project's commissioning, to actively explore opportunities to engage and collaborate with a third-party for the construction of such a facility.

Recommendation and Conclusion

The Committee has critically examined the Agreement within the context of relevant law on the subject and finds that the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources has complied with the legal requirements necessary for granting mining leases. The Committee also finds the mining project to hold a

huge potential to bring tremendous benefits to the country and contribute to the socio-economic development of communities in the lease area.

3:48 p.m.

The Committee respectfully recommends to the House to adopt this Report and ratify by resolution, the Mining Lease Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (Represented by the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources) AND Barari DV Ghana Limited for the Mining of Lithium and other Minerals at Mankessim (42.63 km²) in the Mfantseman Municipality in the Central Region in accordance with Article 268(1) of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any seconder? Yes, Hon Akwasi Konadu.

Deputy Ranking Member of the Committee (Mr Akwasi Konadu): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Report, but in doing so, I would like to place on record that the Report is a Majority decision.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You second the Motion.

Mr Konadu: Mr Speaker, in seconding the Report, I would want to place on record that the Report be amended to reflect that it is a majority decision.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us get it right. The Motion moved is Motion numbered 10 and the

Motion is to adopt the Report. So, you second the Motion, not the Report.

Mr Konadu: Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion numbered 10 on today's *Order Paper*. And in doing so, I would like to place on record some corrections that the Report should be amended to reflect a Majority decision. In the conclusion of the Report, where it is stated that the Committee respectfully recommends to the House, that reflects there.

Mr Speaker, in seconding the Motion, I would like to speak to the Report also with us. First, I would like to talk about paragraph 4.0, which is the background to this Report. The Lithium Agreement is not a new agreement to this House. It was presented to us in the Eighth Parliament, specifically on 16th July, 2024. When the Eighth Parliament elapsed, it was reintroduced to us on 11th November, 2025. However, on 10th December 2025, it was withdrawn, amidst some reasons that we are all accustomed to, and, again, re-presented to us on 19th December, 2025, which has culminated in this Report that we are speaking to.

Mr Speaker, in all of this, it has been a matter of liaising with manoeuvring tactics and a clear incidence for power, but all to the expense of the people on whose lands this natural resource rests, because they have been deprived of a livelihood for a very long time, and it is important that it is placed on record. We, however, cannot belittle the importance of lithium to our Ghanaian economy and to the world. The world is moving

towards a global decarbonisation, which requires that we have green energies to use in our daily activities in this world. So, it is important that once we are blessed with this natural resource, we mine it responsibly and to the benefit of the ordinary Ghanaian and to the State.

So, Mr Speaker, we would want to place on record that there is nothing wrong with us supporting this document. Before I conclude, paragraph 7.5 talked about royalty payments. Royalty payments became a bone of contention on the matter of the lithium agreement, which has reflected in other natural resources, causing a stir in even in gold mining in this country. The reason for this was a point that was raised about the illegality of some negotiated royalties, which was not a matter of fact. While we are trying to cure this, it must be placed on record that we have a Legislative Instrument (L.I) that is trying to regulate a specific provision in our Act. I find it very erroneous that we are using an L.I. to cure a specific provision in our Act.

If need be, for us to talk about royalties, I would be of the opinion that that portion of the Act is amended rather than curing it with an L.I.

However, I know that the mining of lithium will bring about some job creation, which is most importantly needed for our youth in the country. So, it is important that while we have played all that we can with this, it is for us to adopt this Report and ensure that we pass this.

Lastly, Mr Speaker, with local content and participation. This Agreement requires,

in the Clause 4 of section 2, that the mining company or the parent company be listed on the Ghana Stock Exchange, which was done on 13th May 2024, so that local participation in our natural resources can be done by everybody in this country so that anybody who wish to participate in it can purchase it on the Ghana Stock Exchange.

Mr Speaker, in so doing, thank you very much for the opportunity to contribute to this Report and the adoption of it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, let me take the Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources.

Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Alhaji Yusif Sulemana): Mr Speaker, thank you for this opportunity to contribute to this Report and to call on the House to accept the Report and to rectify this Agreement.

Mr Speaker, indeed, we all know the genesis of this very important Agreement. The Minister, being a listening Minister at a point, requested of me to withdraw this Agreement on his behalf, because many Ghanaians were of the view that there was a need for further stakeholder engagement. Very interestingly, the other Side also called for more engagement. He listened to the call, and as a result of that, there have been some enhancements in the agreements. For instance, with reference to paragraph 7.2, where we talk about free carried interest.

In Ghana, we all know that our free carried interest is about 10 per cent in

other minerals. But in this particular one, it has been increased to 13 per cent. And this, for me, is good. It is going to inure to the benefit of this country.

Mr Speaker, the other important point that I want to mention is paragraph 7.7, where the issue of the Community Development Fund is also made as part of this Agreement. Mr Speaker, with your permission, I will read:

“Clause 3 of Schedule 2 to the Mining Lease Agreement provides that ‘the companies shall set aside one per cent of annual revenue for Community Development Fund pursuant to a Community Development Agreement’”

This is very important.

Mr Speaker, before this Agreement, the arrangement was that companies such as Barari and other mining companies would be given the opportunity to come up with what they call Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) which at that point was determined by the companies. There are instances where they go to put up structures that do not really benefit the people. But here we are saying that this one per cent will be set aside and the community will be involved in deciding what this money should be used for. And I think that this is an achievement and progress given where we are coming from. So, I think that it is something we should applaud.

Again, if we look at paragraph 7.10, Mr Speaker, value addition, the President, former Presidents and all of us

here believe that the way to go is to add value to our resources, not only just minerals, but also our farm produce. And this is the time for us to start it with the lithium. So, we are saying that going forward, this lithium agreement is saying that there will be some value addition to whatever lithium is mined. And I think it is very important. This was captured even in the previous Agreement that was laid, and we have carried it on. This is the reason I think that withdrawing it and bringing more people to engage really helped us.

3:58 p.m.

Mr Speaker, there is also a very important point that I want to bring to your attention. If you look at point 7(12) and with your permission, let me read”

“The Committee noted that the Lease Agreement includes a strategic commitment for enhancing maritime and logistical infrastructure in the Saltpond area.”

I think this is very important. Many mining companies go to sites within the communities, it becomes a problem because they even fight with the community for infrastructural development. This is because we have not enshrined it in the Agreement. In this particular instance, it is in this Agreement. So, it becomes an obligation on the part of the company to put out some of these infrastructures when all other conditions are met. I think that this is laudable.

I want to commend the Committee Members and to call on this House to

accept this Report and ratify this Agreement. Because I believe strongly that, it would inure to the benefit of this economy. With this, I want to thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor?

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP —Damongo): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the discussion on this very important Report.

Mr Speaker, at the outset, let me empathise with my immediate successor who has spearheaded the conclusion of this Agreement. With the greatest of respect and in all modesty, I say the word empathise because I do appreciate the complexities, difficulties and complications associated with this kind of negotiation.

Mr Speaker, if you want to appreciate the point I am making — I was first before this House on the 16th July, 2024, to make an attempt to elicit the approval of this House, to get the imprimatur of this House on an Agreement between these same parties. By that, I refer to the Government of the Republic of Ghana represented by the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources and Barari DV Ghana Limited for the mining of lithium.

Mr Speaker, it is the same Agreement. I have the Agreement I presented to this House here with me. I have perused this Report and its terms. The terms of the Agreement I brought before this House, by that, the agreement the Akufo-Addo Government brought before this House and the terms of this

Agreement, are not fundamentally different. They are essentially the same.

Mr Speaker, I will resist the temptation to revisit the politics that was associated with the Agreement, which was presented before this House and was essentially— *[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker.]*

I see Members of the Majority are on their feet. I would correct myself.

Mr Speaker, the Memorandum I laid before this House as the then Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, did not see the light of day, until the expiration of the Eighth Parliament. That is the record. The Memorandum was laid and referred to a committee. However, the process was not concluded. But that is not even my point —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, the fact that you said “it was—by the House”, should be expunged.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, it was not; expunge it. But that is not my point. I will not engage in the semantics of it. Major stakeholders within the body polity of our country including our friends, the NDC, formally and publicly rejected the Agreement I laid before this House and it is on record. That one is a fact and I have the Statement which was issued by the NDC. What is the point I seek to make?

Mr Speaker, I have already said that, the terms are not fundamentally different. Therefore, I conclude on that point to say that today is a happy day for

me and it should be a happy day for former President Akufo-Addo.

Mr Speaker, after all, the suggestion that was made in the run-up to the 2024 election that, President Akufo-Addo, the NPP Government and my modest self, the then Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, had shortchanged the people of Ghana by saying that, we entered a deal and that if we went to South America, there had better models; hence, the Agreement we entered into with Barari DV Ghana Limited was a bad agreement.

On this day, 19th March, 2026, the Report which was laid before this House and the Agreement my successor, the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, Mr Armah-Kofi Buah is urging us to approve, is a huge vindication of the noble work that the Akufo-Addo Government and our good selves did, prior to the 2024 election.

Mr Speaker, with the greatest respect, I want that to be captured by the *Hansard*. Why do I say this? Let us take for instance, the free-carried interest for the Agreement they brought here is 13 per cent. The free-carried interest the Akufo-Addo Government negotiated was 13 per cent. Indeed, we even went a step further to insist that the Minerals Income Investment Fund (MIIF) will necessarily acquire an additional six per cent, which would have meant that the Government of Ghana (GoG) would be entitled to 19 per cent.

Mr Speaker, we did not end there. We insisted that Atlantic Lithium will be

enlisted on the Ghana Stock Exchange (GES) and that a minimum of 40 per cent would be owned by the Ghanaian people.

Mr Speaker, I had the privilege of officially getting Atlantic Lithium to list on the Ghana Stock Exchange and what the Ghanaian people would have gotten would have been 40 per cent and that would have meant this whole operation would be truly an indigenous Ghanaian operation. That was the Agreement we negotiated.

Mr Speaker, we went a step further to ensure that, the Ewoyaa community, would be entitled to a one per cent Community Development Fund. I see this Agreement talks about 13 per cent and I will refer the House, to the page numbered 7 of the Report. There is a classic difference between what the Akufo-Addo Government negotiated for and what is being presented to this House today. What is the difference?

Mr Speaker, with your permission, I quote paragraph 7.3 titled “Interest of Minerals Income Investment Fund in the Project”, it reads:

“The Committee noted that the Minerals Income Investment Fund (MIIF) has taken an equity interest in the parent company, Atlantic Lithium. However, MIIF is yet to take an equity stake in the mining projects. The Committee recommends that the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources take steps to ensure that MIIF takes the equity stake in the mining project as contemplated under the Agreement.”

4:08 p.m.

Mr Speaker, in the case of the Agreement we presented in this House, MIIF’s acquisition of the six per cent in the project was a condition precedent for the project to take off. This particular arrangement is not a condition precedent, which is why the Report says they urge the Ministry to take steps. I would have thought that MIIF taking equity in the project ought to be a condition precedent. Be that as it may, it is a good attempt, but it is not an attempt which is as good as what we presented before this House on 16th July, 2024.

Mr Speaker, finally, and I see the Minister is engaged. When it comes to the green minerals of the world, the most important aspect —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon former Minister, hold it. Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, there is a need for clarity in these matters. He spoke about the equity of MIIF. My understanding is that the 6 per cent interest equity, MIIF is taking equity in Atlantic lithium but that 6 per cent interest is different from taking a stake in the mining project itself. So, which one was a condition precedent? This is because there is some misunderstanding there. So, he should let us have some clarity as to exactly what he is talking about. Because he says that in their agreement, the 6 per cent is a condition precedent but that has been done already. MIIF has taken the 6 per cent already. Now, there is a second phase of it, which

is the project itself, which is what we are urging MIIF to take an interest in the project.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, that is exactly the point I am seeking to make. We are more than happy from this Side to assist our friends to pass this report, to assist my good friend and successor, the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to get on with this Business. Because the management and exploitation of the green minerals of the world is such a difficult task. It is complex one with far-reaching implications and that is why I am concluding on one final point. Mr Speaker, which is that historically, all minerals in our country which have been exploited, we all across the aisle have come to a consensus that we have not gotten the full benefit of these minerals because of the lack of value addition; because these minerals are exported in their raw form, what the pundits would say, dig and ship.

When my senior uncle, Hon Collins Dauda, was the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, it was the same. When I was Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, it was the same. They mine these minerals and they export them without adding value. Which is why, the point was made that in the case of these newly found critical minerals of the future, particularly lithium, we should make a clear effort of adding value to the lithium resource of our country. The agreement I brought before this agreement insisted clearly, not with discretion, it insisted in black and white that the lithium resources of our country

cannot be exported in their raw form and that they will have to be processed to the level of condensates before they can be exported. Therefore, the company was obligated to set up a refinery here in Ghana to refine the lithium they mine into condensate before they can export the mineral.

Mr Speaker, Zimbabwe has actually outrightly banned the export of lithium in its raw form. So, that was the agreement we brought here, which is why I am sounding a word of caution. I have looked through this 12-page report.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon former Minister, can you conclude for me? You would agree that I have given you a length of time.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, let me conclude. The reason I made this point just to enrich the outcome of this discussion.

Mr Speaker, it is very important. If we export the lithium in its raw form, we shortchange our country and our Friends from the other Side, the National Democratic Congress (NDC), made this point very strongly and even cited countries in South America where lithium and other green minerals are being exploited and the kind of arrangements which have been made. In fact, on one occasion, it was even suggested that the State itself should exploit these minerals and that private sector should not be involved and that Ghana should find money to exploit these minerals. If we do not have the money, we should not even mine the

mineral. We should wait. Those were the arguments which were made and I am making the point that the agreement I brought here had a clause in there, a mandatory clause that Barari DV will have to set up a refinery in Ghana and refine our lithium into condensate, value-added form of the lithium, before it is exported. Indeed, they even presented a scoping report. They did research and did the project modelling in setting up a refinery in Ghana, which will ensure that we add value to the lithium resource. I have looked at this 12-page report and that is missing. That is troubling. That is disturbing. Every Ghanaian should be concerned. Civil society should be concerned. This House should be concerned. The Majority should be concerned.

Mr Speaker, I conclude by saying that, the old people say that we should pray to the Almighty to live long and we shall see a lot. If we had ended on the 16th of July, 2024, we would not see this day, the 19th of March, 2026. We will not see that this same Agreement is being presented to this House with 13 per cent free carried interest that we negotiated for 19 per cent. We will not see that this Agreement will be presented to this House without a provision of value addition. We will not see that the Agreement that is being presented is fundamentally the same as what was opposed by our Friends.

Mr Speaker, on that note, may they withdraw this Report. They laid it on 11th November, 2025, withdrew it on 10th December. They laid it again on 19th December. It is still not too late. The

lithium resources are so important to the Ghanaian people. We are opposed to this report. Find a way of refining it so that we can add value to the lithium resources of our country for the benefit of Ghanaians. That is what will help our country.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, you will conclude.

Yes, Hon Sanja Nanja?

Mr Sanja Nanja (NDC—Atebubu/Amantin): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Motion numbered 10 on today's *Order Paper* that this honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources on the Mining Lease Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources) and Barari DV Ghana Limited for the mining of Lithium and other minerals at Mankessim (42.63 km²) in the Mfantseman Municipality of the Central Region.

Mr Speaker, today, one of the challenges that we are facing with mining is the protection of our environment. The Committee was particular about how the company will preserve our environment and the Chief Executive Officer of the Environmental Protection Authority (EPA) assured us that even though the environmental permit that was granted to the company has expired, every process is being put in place. The renewal of the environmental

protection permit will soon be granted to the company. He also went further to assure the Committee that the company shall ensure —

4:18 p.m.

The Agreement went further to assure us that the Company shall ensure conservation of resources, reclamation of land and protection of our environment.

Mr Speaker, one other area that we looked at was job creation. As at now, if this Agreement is rectified, this Company would employ over a thousand youth in the catchment area for direct mining jobs. Indirect jobs are unquantifiable.

Mr Speaker, it is also worthy of note that on taxes, the Company is not given waivers or exemption from taxes. All the taxes that are enshrined in our legislations and statutes will be paid to the Government. Royalties will equally be paid according to the prescribed laws in the sliding scale of today. As we speak, comparing the price of lithium to our sliding scale, the Government would earn a royalty of 10 per cent. As the lithium prices keep increasing at the world market, the royalty could rise up to 12 per cent.

Mr Speaker, on job creation, the chiefs, and people of the catchment area, opinion leaders, assembly members, youth groups, community-based organisations (CBOs), and all identifiable groups in the area were invited to our meeting. I should say that the chiefs and the people have fully given their support

to this project, in the sense that when this project comes to the area, their local economy would be boosted. Also, they would see massive development, social amenities, especially with the annual community development fund of 1 per cent, which will accrue US\$6 million to the community within a year.

So, Mr Speaker, given the support that the chiefs and the people from the area are giving to the project, the Committee recommended that the House ratify this Agreement so that the economy can be boosted and youth in the place can get jobs to do.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I call on the House to ratify the Agreement.

Thank you.

Dr Mohammed Amin Adam (NPP — Karaga): Mr Speaker, I take for granted the fact that this Report made provision for environmental issues in the contract area and indeed stated that the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA), will be required to issue an environmental permit before any operations can take place. But, in my view, the environmental provisions in the Agreement are not adequate.

Lithium production has significant negative footprint. The key environmental issues relate to water contamination, soil degradation and pollution, waste generation, and even electronic waste (e-waste). The footprint is quite colossal wherever lithium is being produced. Environmental permit really, does not

address environmental mitigation because the permit is issued before the operation starts. But during operations, when there is an environmental disaster, how would it be mitigated? The Agreement has to provide for it.

In most jurisdictions, the Polluter Pay Principle applies; but even with the Polluter Pay Principle, it is important that financial guarantees are provided so that when there is an environmental disaster, the Company does not give an excuse that they do not have sufficient resources to mitigate it. This is why, in addition to the Polluter Pay Principle, financial guarantees must be provided.

Mr Speaker, two ways of addressing this is to request the Company to post an environmental bond so that in the event of such a disaster, the bond is liquidated to mitigate the effect of the disaster. The other way to do this is to set up an environmental mitigation fund so that a certain percentage of the revenue from the sale of the products will be put into the fund to be used to mitigate against any disaster when it occurs. These are all absent in the Agreement, and therefore, I side with my Colleague that this Report be withdrawn and these major environmental mitigation issues are addressed, because that is very key. Mr Speaker, if they are not addressed, then I will have a difficulty voting for this Report.

Mr Speaker, due to the environmental concerns, communities that will be affected are too exposed, but I see only 1 per cent of annual revenue required to be put in a community

development fund. This may not be enough if we match it against the enormous negative footprint lithium production could bring to our communities. So, I propose that we increase it to 2 per cent, or 3 per cent, so that communities are properly compensated because of the effects they would have to contend with and the risk associated with lithium production.

Mr Speaker, if we cannot do this, we will be exposing the communities without preparing to provide the amenities that could help them cope with the footprint lithium production would bring on them.

So, Mr Speaker, with these two issues, I think it needs to be looked at seriously. Therefore, if our Friends on the other Side would agree to withdraw this Report and address these issues, we would all be happy when they bring the Report back with these modifications. We will all be happy to support this, and I believe Ghanaians will support it fully.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership?

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, I rise to sum up the views of this Side of the House, the Minority Caucus.

Mr Speaker, the Report before us is in respect of the revised Mining Lease Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana and the Barari DV Ghana Limited, a subsidiary of Atlantic

Lithium Limited, granting rights for the mining of lithium and other associated minerals at Ewoyaa in the Mfantseman municipality, Central Region, a region where I come from.

The Agreement is presented for ratification pursuant to Article 268(1) of the 1992 Constitution.

4:28 p.m.

Mr Speaker, let me state for the record that this Side of the House, the Minority, is ever ready at all times to support development of Ghana's lithium resources. Since the development of these resources would amount to job creation, increased opportunities and creates an economic hub in the Central Region which the Report, has it, that Central Region has a high level of poverty because of lack of jobs.

Mr Speaker, the project at Ewoyaa represent a historic opportunity for Ghana to participate in global green energy transition. But our concerns are the terms on which the Government proposes to cede these rights over Ghana's mineral endowments. The regulatory architecture that now frames those terms and the pace at which Parliament is being asked to act—it is upon these that the Minority oppose this Agreement in its present form and shape. Earlier, my respected Colleague, Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, and my own Senior, Dr Mohammed Adam, had cause to reiterate the views of our Caucus.

Mr Speaker, my duty is to provide a summation of all related issues

underlining our reason for rejecting this Report.

Mr Speaker, you may recall that in October 2023, the Nana Akufo-Addo Administration negotiated and signed a mining lease with Barari DV Ghana Limited, securing:

- i. a royalty rate of 10 per cent, elevated from the statutory floor of 5 per cent,
- ii. a free carried interest of 13 per cent for the State,
- iii. an additional 6 per cent equity stake through the Minerals Income and Investment Fund, bringing the total participation to a reported 19 per cent,
- iv. and a requirement for local stock exchange listing.

Our Friends, then in Opposition, vehemently rejected and blocked the ratification. They argued that the terms were insufficient, and as a result, the Agreement lapsed and it was unratified at the Dissolution of the Eighth Parliament. Upon assuming office in January 2025, the NDC Administration renegotiated this Agreement. The product of that renegotiation is an agreement that, at current market price, it yields a royalty of 5 per cent, the same statutory floor that prevailed before the negotiation of the NPP, and at the prevailed price of US\$2,250 per tonne. When the original 10 per cent was negotiated in 2023, it will yield only 7 per cent under the new sliding scale.

Mr Speaker, it is further on record that Barari DV Ghana Limited was prepared to proceed with the project under the original 10 per cent fixed royalty. The Minority invited this House to place that fact alongside the decision of the Government to grant concessions and to demand a full and frank explanation for that reversal.

Mr Speaker, first, we would want to invite this House to look at the regulatory context. In this sense, we proceed to submit that the Legislative Instrument (L.I) and the Growth and Sustainability Levy (Amendment) Act (GSL) ought to be critically looked at.

Mr Speaker, in drawing the attention of the House to the regulatory sequence that immediately preceded this debate. As it is directly material to any vote on this mining lease, the Minerals and Mining Royalty Regulation, 2025, our Colleague, the Chairperson of Subsidiary Legislation, sounded the alarm bell, but our friends would not listen.

On December 19, 2025, our respected Colleague, a former Deputy Minority Leader and now a Minister of State responsible for this Sector, laid the Minerals and Mining Royalty Regulation, 2025, before Parliament, introducing a sliding scale royalty regime for gold, lithium and other minerals.

Mr Speaker, for lithium and spodumene, the price band are 5 per cent, that is up to US\$1,500 per tonne; 7 per cent, for US\$1,501 to US\$2,500 per tonne; 10 per cent, which is US\$2,501 to

US\$3,000 per tonne; and 12 per cent, which is above 3,000 tonnes.

Mr Speaker, the Legislative Instrument matured into law on 9th March, 2026 having completed the constitutionally required 21 sitting days without amendment. Our Caucus, the Minority, notes that at the time of the original NPP negotiation in 2023, the spodumene prices stood at approximately US\$2,250 per tonne, yielding a 10 per cent fixed royalty. Under the new framework of the Government, the same price of US\$2,250 falls within the 7 per cent band. In other words, the sliding scale delivers a lower royalty than the fixed rate that existed when the deal was first made, at precisely the price level used as a reference point for that deal. This is not an improvement on the NPP steps. At any price below US\$2,500 per tonne, it is a regression and we beg to submit.

Mr Speaker, our Colleague, Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah, warned publicly on 10th March, 2026, that the royalty Regulation could cost Ghana close to 1 million jobs by deterring mining investment. Those concerns were not resolved before the L.I matured. Parliament now faces a request to ratify a mining lease governed by a regulatory Instrument about which the most fundamental concerns of the Minority remain outstanding.

Mr Speaker, let me delve into the Growth and Sustainability Levy Act, 2026, as amended. Parliament has passed the Growth and Sustainability (Amendment) Act, 2026, reducing the

levy on mining companies from 3 per cent to 1 per cent of gross production. The Government stated that the rationale was that GSL increase from 1 per cent to 3 per cent was originally introduced to compensate for the absence of the windfall tax mechanism, and that the new sliding scale royalty regime now performs that function. Mr Speaker, we disagree.

We urge this House to delay the Third Reading of that Bill for further scrutiny because stakeholders were expressing concern, especially our bilateral partners. However, this House proceeded over that objection. We, however, draw the attention of Parliament to the net effect. Whatever additional royalty revenue the sliding scale regime is projected to generate must be assessed against the revenue foregone through the GSL reduction. The Government has not presented Parliament with a consolidated net revenue analysis, and Parliament cannot responsibly ratify this lease without understanding what Ghana is, on the balance, actually gaining. I repeat, we do not know what we are actually gaining, and we are being asked to ratify this.

Mr Speaker, we want to now turn to our concerns as a Caucus regarding the revised terms on the royalty structure and unverified financial assumptions. Mr Speaker, it is our contention that Government has accepted the claims of the Atlantic Lithium that a sharp decline in global lithium prices of approximately 80 per cent from 2022 to 2023 peak, renders the project unviable under a 10 per cent fixed royalty, and that its post-

tax internal rate of return has collapsed to 13.6 per cent. The Minority notes that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, Hon Abednego— Is Abednego, the Member who turned his back towards the Mace?

Hon Member, you may continue.

4:38 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Minority notes that the Natural Resource Governance Institute (NRGI) has modelled the project independently and found it economically viable even at US\$785 per tonne of spodumene concentrate. The company has not publicly disclosed the assumptions involved in its revised Internal Rate of Return (IRR) estimate. Parliament is being invited to ratify royalty concessions premised on financial projections that remain unverified and undisclosed. This is not a sound basis for the exercise of Parliament's ratification function under Article 268 of the 1992 Constitution.

Secondly on the transfer pricing and off-take risk, Piedmont Lithium holds approximately 22.5 per cent equity in the Ewoyaa project and has entered an off-take Agreement to purchase 50 per cent of the project's production for its United States of America (USA) refining operations. Mr Speaker, refineries outside of China routinely require below-benchmark pricing to remain viable. If Barari DV sells spodumene to Piedmont at below-benchmark prices, Ghana's royalty base computed on mine revenues is correspondingly reduced.

The Minority is not satisfied that the revised Agreement or the royalty regulation's L.I. adequately addresses this risk through benchmark-based pricing requirements or related party transaction protection. Mr Speaker, it has to be emphasised that these concerns were raised when the L.I. came up for consideration, but our Friends opposite ignored.

The third issue has to do with community impact. We acknowledge the genuine hardship endured by farming families and communities in the concession area where a moratorium on farmland has disrupted livelihood for over two years. Communities in Ewoyaa, Amansie, Nankesedo, Anokye, Abonko and Twafo have been patient and have waited long. Our Side of the House is not indifferent to that reality.

However, Mr Speaker, we beg to submit that the urgency of community relief does not justify a structurally weak Agreement. A one per cent community development fund from gross revenue, while welcomed, does not compensate for a royalty regime that at current prices, delivers the statutory minimum. These communities deserve both a timely resolution and an Agreement that maximises the long-term royalty and development dividends available to them and to the Republic.

Mr Speaker, on the basis of all that I have submitted, on behalf of my Colleagues, the following are our demands—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader, just a minute. Hon James Agalga?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: They do not have their numbers. He should not cause any problem that would create further problems for them. He should continue what he is doing. There is an agreement at Leadership level, then he comes back to rise on a point of order. He should continue. He will see the consequences.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, I hold you in high esteem, but it is not everything that you should be placing into the *Hansard*. Yes?

Mr James Agalga: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader is intimidating me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me hear you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Minority that holds the conscience of society and this democracy hereby submits the following for the consideration of this House.

First, net revenue analysis. Mr Speaker, we request that the Minister table, before any vote is taken, a consolidated net revenue analysis comparing the projected state revenues and the New Patriotic Party's (NPP) original fixed 10 per cent royalty against those under the revised sliding scale regime; and the net of the Growth and Sustainability Levy (GSL) reduction from three per cent to one per cent. Parliament cannot assess the value of this Agreement in isolation from its companion legislative changes.

Second, Mr Speaker, we demand a full disclosure of financial assumptions. The Minority requests that the Minister make available the full financial model and revised assumptions submitted by Atlantic Lithium and Barari DV Ghana Limited in support of its request for royalty concessions including the basis for the claimed IRR of 13.6 per cent. I expect the Minister to take note and respond appropriately.

Third, benchmark pricing protections. We have done a lot of research on this matter. They cannot take it for granted. It is not mere politics we are doing. They should take note. The Minority requests that the Minister confirm whether the revised Agreement includes benchmark-based pricing requirements for uptake sales to related parties including Piedmont Lithium. If not, we want to see proposals for such provisions which should be made and submitted before this ratification.

Fourth, transfer pricing and anti-avoidance. We also call for an explicit protection in the Agreement against profit shifting through related party transactions, including limits on interest deductions and clear dividend distribution rules consistent with the recommendations of the NRGi. They are already aware of their recommendation. It was brought to them.

Fifth, non-dilution of state equity. This is very critical and the Minister must pay attention to this. The Minority requests confirmation that the revised Agreement includes a non-dilution clause protecting the equity

stake of the state from reduction through future capital costs or corporate restructuring. A lot of times, Ghana has suffered under this where there is a way these investors dilute their shares under restructuring in one way or the other. We want to be sure that the Minister has actually secured for us, as a country, a non-dilution clause that will protect our interests.

Sixth, community development fund governance. The Minority also demands full details of the governance, disbursement structure and the oversight mechanism for one per cent community development fund to ensure that host communities receive the promised benefits in a timely and accountable manner.

Now we speak for the people. Most of the time, when such investors come, they abandon the community. We do not just want talks. It should be enshrined in the document that they want us to ratify today, so that the local people will benefit from this. Else, Mr Speaker, if we sign this document and Parliament approves this today, that will be the end of the local people. If the Majority is not looking at this, we on this Side of the House stand with the people.

Mr Speaker, we also demand from our respected Minister, independent expert assessment. We call on Parliament to invite from credible institutions, including NRGi and the Ghana Revenue Authority to conduct an independent assessment of the revised terms and their long-term net revenue implication before this ratification.

4:48 p.m.

Mr Speaker, with all this said, we humbly conclude by saying that at any point that the Ministry and its Minister are able to come to the table for further engagement on these key concerns and ensure that the Agreement factors these in, we, the Minority, will be ready to support the ratification. Mr Speaker, currently, however, we are not prepared at all to endorse this Agreement as same is premised on unverifiable financial assumptions governed by a regulatory Instrument rushed into law over the Minority's initial objection and structured in a manner that, at the current and recent price levels, delivers an unacceptable royalty than the deal the same NDC rejected in opposition.

Our country's lithium endowment is a generational asset. The terms on which it is leased will outlast the Ninth Parliament, and we will define the revenue, employment, and community development benefits that flow to Ghana for the duration of the mine's life. Parliament has a constitutional *bona fide* under Article 268 of the 1992 Constitution to scrutinise those terms with rigour, not to validate a legislative sequence that has been engineered to foreclose a debate.

Mr Speaker, we therefore call on this House, and in fact we insist on the disclosures and the protections outlined in our submission before a vote is taken. We owe that standard of care to the people of Ewoyaa, the people of Ghana, and above all, the integrity of this House and its parliamentary oversight. Mr

Speaker, I respectfully submit, therefore, that the Agreement in its current form and shape is opposed, and the Government must not wait on Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) to come with their criticism before they do another U-turn.

Mr Speaker, all that said, I rest my case without more. Thank you very much.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, if my Colleague, the Minority Leader, had served me a copy of what he just read, I would have also prepared a lengthy Statement to read. Mr Speaker, I have not brought before me a written script, but I will speak *extempore* and respond to him. Mr Speaker, let it be known that the former Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, my very good Friend, Hon Samuel A. Jinapor, has said that there is no material difference between the Agreement that he brought to this House and the Agreement that we are considering today. There is no material difference, and it is in essence the same Agreement.

Mr Speaker, I think it is important to know that —

Mr S. A. Jinapor — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jinapor.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, most respectfully, for the record, I did not say what the Majority Leader is attributing to me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What did you say?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, I did not.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader should stop intimidating his Members. He is urging them to say something different from the things that they said openly before the cameras just a few minutes ago. We were all in this Chamber when he did a comparison of the Agreement that he brought as a Minister and the Agreement that is before us, and concluded that, in essence, there is no difference. So, why did the National Democratic Congress (NDC) oppose, when in essence, what he brought and what the NDC brought are the same?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: In fact, he added that he has been vindicated.

Mr Ayariga: And then he said that he has been vindicated. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker is reminding us of what was said. Mr Speaker is responsible for the records of this House and so what has been said, he can remind us to straighten us.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader has a duty to ensure the peace of this House. Today is the last day of Ramadan, and tomorrow is Eid. I do not want the Majority Leader to lead any of us here into temptation. He knows the conditions behind him, and if he

knows his own condition, he should not attempt to bring trouble to this Side of the House. We have told him that we are opposed to this, and he should not now pick us out of context. Mr Speaker, you are the Presiding Officer. Do not be tempted by the Majority Leader. Mr Speaker, *mede kuku na wò*, to wit: I beg you. If the Majority Leader can be brief, he should be brief.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, when the Minority Leader, before the cameras, pleads with you to be brief, you have to be brief. So, I will be very brief. Which is to say, Mr Speaker should put the question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: In fact, you have to conclude. *[Laughter]*

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I conclude. *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, would you want to give a concluding remark?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I thank you very much, and thank Members for the very valuable contributions. I have taken note of all the contributions, especially the long speech by the Minority Leader. Mr Speaker, it is important that I point out key changes to this Agreement. Indeed, there are provisions in this Agreement that did not change, but there are fundamental changes that I must note. For example, in their old Agreement, on the Growth and Sustainability Levy, we now have flexibility. They had a fix—*[Interruption]*—it is important. Please, it

is the same Agreement; I am not contradicting the Leader, and I cannot contradict my Leader. But it is important to point out that, for example, there is a new provision that says: “The Company is further obliged to pay to the Government of Ghana all other fees, levies, charges, and penalties as provided under applicable laws...”. Under the old Agreement, it was fixed at 1 per cent. Here, there is flexibility to allow the Government of Ghana to “clock in” [*sic*] anytime there is that opportunity. So, that flexibility has been provided.

Mr Speaker, in terms of royalty, as we all know, we had a fixed royalty of 10 per cent—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, I will urge you to also make it brief.

4:58 p.m.

Mr Buah: I am making it brief.

Mr Speaker, it is important that I point out that this new Agreement has really made critical provisions that are important and we must point them out. There was a lot of noise — [**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Noise?]
— made about the fact that royalty was reduced to 5 per cent. Today I am proud to say that at the current rate, the royalty will be 12 per cent and not the 10 per cent fixed rate because of the sliding scale that has been approved by this House.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I withdraw “noise”. Let us make progress.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, “noise” is withdrawn.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, there is something very important that I must also add. It is a new addition. We wanted to be sure that the mining of lithium will not also come to add to the destruction of our roads in the mining communities. So, a critical provision that has been inserted is that within six months from the ratification of this lease Agreement, the company will undertake a feasibility study for the construction of a jetty, a barge, and a mini port system of appropriate size. This is very important because we want to make sure that we do not focus on destroying our road.

Mr Speaker, I think that it is a very important for the people of Ewoyaa and other communities who have waited for almost three years because there is a lot that will happen in this community when this project takes off. I would want to urge all Members, especially, the Minority, to defy their Leadership and support the Majority to approve this Agreement— [**An Hon Member:** Defy?]
— I withdraw that. They should join us in approving this Agreement.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think we have concluded the debates. Minority Leader after the conclusion of the debate what else—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I just want to put on record that the entire 87 Members of the Minority Caucus of this House votes *en bloc* against this Agreement. To the extent that the Minister did not carry our concerns on board and insists on carrying the Report in its present form and shape, we cannot be part of this. Therefore, Mr Speaker, we vote *en bloc* rejecting this, that is, when, Mr Speaker, you put the Question. We are signalling that when the Question is put, this Side of the House, all 87 of us are voting *en bloc*—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, you know, you cannot put something on nothing and expect it to stand.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I know, but I am serving notice so that when you put the Question, you know that this is our position. We want the *Hansard* to capture same so that when you put the Question, we do not need to come back. The *Hansard* should capture that when the Question is put for the ratification of this Agreement, the 87 Members of the Minority Caucus will vote *en bloc* and we hereby vote *en bloc* against this Agreement.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Minority Leader, what happens if part of

the Minority votes in favour or against the Motion?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I am saying that we are against it because the concerns we expressed have not been addressed.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us proceed to take the consequential Resolution numbered 11 at page 4 of the *Order Paper* for today.

Yes, Hon Minister for Lands and Natural Resources?

RESOLUTION

Mining Lease Agreement Between GoG and Barari DV Ghana Limited

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

WHEREAS

1. By the provisions of Article 268(1) of the Constitution, any transaction, contract or undertaking involving the grant of a right or concession by or on behalf of any person or body of persons howsoever described, for the exploitation of any mineral, water or other natural resource of Ghana made or entered into after the coming into force of the Constitution is made subject to ratification by Parliament;

2. In pursuance of the said Article 268(1) of the Constitution, the Government of Ghana has caused to be laid before Parliament through the Minister responsible for Lands and Natural Resources the Mining Lease Agreement Between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources) and Barari DV Ghana Limited for the mining of Lithium and other minerals at Mankessim (42.63 km²) in the Mfantseman Municipality of the Central Region.

Now therefore, this House in accordance with the said Article 268(1) of the Constitution hereby resolve to ratify the said the Mining Lease Agreement Between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources) and Barari DV Ghana Limited for the mining of Lithium and other minerals at Mankessim (42.63 km²) in the Mfantseman Municipality of the Central Region.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Minister has moved the Resolution. Any seconder?

Alhaji Yusif Sulemana: Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we hope to end the day at this point, but there is a matter that has been pending for a long time, which the establishment of the Ad hoc Committee for the purposes of auditing the Report on the Financial Statement of the Office of the Auditor-General, the Motion numbered 18. It is a brief one and we can just take it—*[Interruption]*. No, it is a Motion to establish the Committee. There will be no debate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Shaib, this is a Committee which is already formed by both Sides.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, let us always go by our words and have good faith in every engagement. I understand that. There are several other things. I agree we just have to move the Motion. Let us take it on Tuesday.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The membership has already been agreed upon by the House—

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, let us take it on Tuesday. Mr Speaker, let us end on a good note.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, this is a very important Motion; a Motion that is to lead to the constitution of an Ad hoc Committee that will audit the accounts of the Auditor-General, which is the constitutional imperative; and we agreed that we will do this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, for me, this is a consequential

matter because both Sides of the House have already agreed on the membership of this Committee made up of Hon Kofi Bente Afful, Hon Matthew Nyindam, and Hon Atta Issa. Both Sides of the House has already agreed on this, so this is just a formality.

Mr Shaib: We could have done it earlier. We could have agreed on same. Mr Speaker, all of these—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But it is better late than never. We would have done this by now.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, we could have done other things that are also consequential. *[Interruption]* No, we did not agree on that at Conclave. I was at Conclave and we never agreed. Let us stop this and be fair to ourselves. What is wrong if we close on this note and come back on Tuesday to take it?

Mr Speaker, respectfully, I would want to raise the issue of quorum.

5:08 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, let me hear from you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, this is the *Order Paper* for today. This is a Business that is advertised to be taken today and we agreed at Conclave that we would take it. Hon Shaib would have to stop these things. We had agreed. *[Interruption]* Yes, we had agreed. *[Interruption]* This his insistence that a Business that has been advertised to be taken today, he gets up and says that he

would not take it—On what authority is he saying that a Government Business cannot be taken? *[Uproar]* So can his Caucus say that a Business cannot be taken? *[Uproar]* We will take it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, let me hear from you, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, respectfully, let me reiterate the point that at Conclave we discussed issues to be dealt with today. This was not part of it and I am saying that in good faith, we have decided to do a lot of things on Tuesday. This can be taken on Tuesday. The two Leaders can have an understanding. Mr Speaker, I am not against this. I am not against accountability. My name is not mentioned in anything. I am dealing with good faith and goodwill. That is all. When I am talking, my Brother, Hon Rockson, should understand that I also represent a Caucus. So, I talk based on what the Caucus has agreed for me to come and deal with. So, it has nothing to do with me personally. He should stop being personal about this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: When I am looking at this particular Business, I cannot describe this to be a Government Business because the various Caucuses have agreed on their own Members to form a Committee in order to do an act. However, that is supposed to be adopted by the House. To put a Question to adopt it, I do not see any difficulty about it. Because both Sides have submitted names, and the names have been put together for the House to adopt. So, this is not any Business that will even be

debated. Because this is consequent upon the two Sides of the House agreeing that three people should go and perform an act.

Hon Members, within a second, we can take this. The Motion numbered 18, Majority Leader?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, before the Majority Leader comes in, respectfully, if you insist, because I believe that this is a Parliament of two Sides, and I believe that consistently we should show good faith when we agree on matters—Mr Speaker, respectfully, if it is your view and you want to go ahead, that is fine.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But I agree with you that Parliament is made up of two Sides. Now, one Side has produced a name, and the other Side has also produced a name so the House should adopt whatever the two Sides have proposed. The Motion numbered 18 is just agreeing on what the Caucuses have already agreed upon to do a particular work. That is all. The Caucuses are not now going to agree. They have already agreed, and have put the names together.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, my recollection is that you were going to take this Motion yesterday, but both Sides said they were tired and I am told that you said we should take it today. So, it is an agreement that we had yesterday and the Members on the Committee drew my attention, that this thing has been pending. This is not Government Business. This is actually our Business as a Parliament and it is the responsibility

of my Colleagues and I to make sure that this Committee is established. There is a very important name on the Committee, Hon Matthew Nyindam. So, if there is a Committee and Hon Matthew Nyindam is a member, and they are seen opposing the establishment of that Committee, it does not look good for their Side. *[Laughter] [Interruption]* Exactly, it has been there for a long time so why are you keeping Matthew waiting for this long?

MOTION

Composition of Ad Hoc Committee to Recommend an Auditor for Auditing the Auditor-General's 2024 Financial Statements

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That this honourable House constitutes an Ad hoc Committee made up of the following Members to recommend for appointment by Parliament an Auditor to audit and report on the Financial Statements of the Office of the Auditor-General for the Year ended 31st December, 2024:

1. Hon Kofi Bente Afful - Chairman
2. Hon Matthew Nyindam - Member
3. Hon Atta Issa - Member

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion has been moved. Any seconder?

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, clearly this is not a Motion that calls for a debate because both Sides of the House have already agreed on the composition of the Committee.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, having adopted the Motion, it is to be placed on record that the following Members are recommended for appointment to audit and report the Financial Statements of the Office of the Auditor-General for the year ending 31st December, 2024. The Members are:

1. Hon Kofi Bente Afful - Chairman
2. Hon Matthew Nyindam - Member
3. Hon Atta Issa - Member

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the proposal is that they submit a Report within 30 days.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. The Committee is to work and report to the House within 30 days.

Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it is 5:15 p.m. and we have done nearly five hours. On that note, I move that in the absence of any further Business, the House be adjourned until Tuesday at midday.

I so move, Mr Speaker.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, we are not opposed to the application, save that we were wishing to see the 189 battalion. Mr Speaker, let me also take this opportunity

to wish Dr Mahamudu Bawumia a Happy Eid and all Muslims in Ghana, especially those in the Effutu, Damongo, Weija-Gbawe, Anyaa Sowutuom, Bawku Central; we wish all of them a Happy Eid. *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry Ahmed, but we have already commented on the Eid ul-Fitr Statement?

Hon Members, Motion moved and seconded. It is for the consideration of the House.

Yes?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am not arresting the Motion, but a job I have is also to see to it that Members visit their constituencies well prepared. Mr Speaker, the Chief Whip of the Majority Caucus is supposed to be in charge of key welfare issues of Members.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect, please, do not state this into the record.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No, Mr Speaker, I am talking about the Common Fund. I am talking about constituency issues and statutory allocations. Mr Speaker, statutory allocations are very important. He is the Majority Chief Whip. He is supposed to get the Ministers to work in ensuring that Members of Parliament (MPs) get what is required of them in their constituencies to do their work. *[Hear! Hear!]* We have a long holiday. MPs are going to face their constituent and we have a Majority Chief Whip who is sitting here and always comes to tell the Ministers to do their job. Mr Speaker, Members have

concerns and he should know. They are supposed to get projects done in their constituencies. They are supposed to see to the welfare of their constituents. That is his responsibility. Nobody forced Chief Whip on him. He wanted to be a Chief Whip so he should wake up and do his job well. If he cannot do his job, he should resign. *[Laughter] [Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker —

Question put and Motion agreed to.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 5:21 p.m. till Tuesday, 24th March, 2026 at 10:00 a.m.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was adopted by the House on 27th March, 2026.